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Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28337871.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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by wingedcorgi

Summary

Catra starts paying regular visits to Glimmer in Horde Prime's prison.

Notes

I wrote this as a Christmas gift to my dearest best friend Maria, who just so happens to be Glimmer personified. But I hope everyone else can enjoy it too!

Glimmer

As far as prisons go, Glimmer has seen worse.

The cell is brightly-lit, with plenty of space for stretching and nervously pacing around, there's even a chair, a table, and a bed she can throw herself onto in her fits of despair. Certainly better than the chamber she was held in back at Fright Zone. The lack of magical restraints that would send an electric current through every inch of her body whenever she attempted teleportation is definitely an improvement.

Not that it matters much, seeing as she can't teleport out either way.

She tries to count her blessings and stay positive, she really does. But the helplessness is truly getting to her. One minute she stares at the wall mindlessly, the next she remembers the sight of Bow and Adora fighting Prime's clones back on Etheria and she jolts upwards, heaving as if she's just ran for miles. She feels like crying and screaming, but that is about the extent of what she can do right now. She hasn't spoken to Prime since their "dinner" and that was… she's not even sure how long it's been since. Two days? A week? With no day and night outside it was difficult to tell. Perhaps it happened only a few hours ago and she's been slipping in and out of naps ever since.

Maybe this is Prime's insidious method of torturing her. This bright cell hurting her eyes, this deafening silence around her, the clones bringing her meals at random times to confuse her… The hours of sitting cross-legged on the floor, not knowing what became of her friends, thinking of all the ways they could be dying right now and realizing it is all her own fault and there is nothing she can do about it now, nothing at all…

Or maybe it's not and she's doing all this to herself.

The guilt alone is enough to wreck her. She had plenty of time to reminiscence the past year and how terribly she's treated her friends. How she used Adora repeatedly. How she betrayed Bow's trust. There was a rift between them she created all by herself, and for what? She wanted to defeat the Horde, bring peace to Etheria and instead she caused its greatest disaster. And worst of all, she wasn't even sure if she's done it out of her sense of responsibility as a queen, or out of desire to prove herself to be more capable of a leader than Adora.

Some queen she is. Her mother would be so disappointed in her.

The sound of footsteps pierces through silence, so Glimmer looks up at the green half-transparent door of her cell. Prime's clone no. 527, or whichever one that is, stands there with a tray of food. As she walks up closer to the door, he gives her a perfunctory nod with a small unaware smile.

"Here's your meal, your majesty," he says in monotone, then puts his hand up to the door. They flicker and disappear, just long enough for him to place the tray over.

Glimmer says nothing. She's thought about performing some sort of an act of defiance – refusing food or throwing it at her guard's face – but first she needs to come up with something this would achieve. So far she couldn't think of anything useful.

The clone stands back and the door reappears, giving his ghostly white face a tinge of a hideous lime green. For a moment, Glimmer thinks she sees the light changing in his eyes, like a flickering lightbulb, as his smile fades and he walks away.

She walks up to the tray and examines the contents. The food looks relatively normal. The crackers look fine and the soup appears thick enough to stand a spoon up in, but at least it doesn't resemble the space jelly. She picks the tray up and turns around to neatly place it on the table.

Then immediately drops it, seeing the person sitting in her bed.

“MOTHERF--!” she exclaims, before instinctively slapping her own mouth shut. She takes a deep breath before speaking again “What the HELL are you doing here?!”

Catra eyes her with a mildly curious expression, completely unfazed by her outburst. She looks as villainous as ever, in her dark suit and hair slicked back, pupils of her mismatched eyes turned into thin slits by the bright lights. As usual, she has a small, vicious smirk plastered on her face – Glimmer can hardly remember ever seeing her face without it.

“Visiting,” Catra says, voice sligthly hoarse, baring her pointy fangs in a smile. “Didn’t you see me coming in?”

Her voice is mockingly concerned and suddenly Glimmer feels like punching her. She doesn’t care if this would have any long-term benefits or not.

“How… When did you…?” Glimmer stammers indignantly.

“I have my ways, Sparkles,” Catra says, leaning against Glimmer’s pillows as if she’s never been more comfortable. Somehow her face is looking more punchable with every passing second.

“You don’t want to tell me,” Glimmer crosses her arms. “Fine. Would you at least let me know why you’re even here?”

“Who knows,” Catra says, dragging one of her claws lightly against the linen.

“You do, Horde scum,” Glimmer scowls. “Why are you here again?”

“I love what you’ve done with the place,” Catra points out, acting as if she didn’t hear her at all and looking poignantly at the soup now spilled all over the floor. She stands up and strolls around the room at a leisurely pace. “How do you like it here?”

“The accommodation is amazing. Five stars. Food could use some improvement, though. The soup is thicker than your skull.”

Catra chuckles at that, to Glimmer's surprise.

"Looks better than the last cell I've stayed at," she says. Glimmer raises her eyebrows.

"Alright, I'll bite. When was the last time you've stayed in a cell?"

"A little over a year ago."

"Did they finally lock you up for being too annoying?"

"No, but funnily enough I think that's what you're in here for, princess."

"It's 'queen' now."



Under any other circumstance, Glimmer would probably resort to violence already, consequences be damned. She still hates Catra – so much. Thinking of everything she's done to her, her friends, family, kingdom… There were so many times Glimmer wished this pointy-eared menace would just straight up go ahead and die and she's only ever stopped herself from vocalizing her thoughts to spare Adora's feelings.

But as things are right now, Glimmer would honestly rather spend time with Catra, of all people, than be left to stare at the walls alone again. The solitude is suffocating and having someone other than Prime's mindless clones to interact with her feels like a breath of fresh air.

The most infuriating, evil, punchable fresh air ever.

Plus, there was another thing – that time she cornered Catra in the Fright Zone. Glimmer gives it a lot of thought – lately she has all the time in the world for thinking – and still can't think of a reason why Catra didn't fight her back. And then what was her stepping in to stop Prime all about? And why did she come here to make small talk with Glimmer earlier?

Something is definitely off with her. It's intriguing, and, if nothing else, a nice distraction from Glimmer's own plight. So she tries to refrain from doing or saying anything that will surely chase Catra away immediately. Just pretend they're having a normal, casual conversation.

They both say nothing for what feels like several minutes, Catra still avoiding Glimmer's gaze. Eventually, she clears her throat.

"So, sleepovers, huh?" she finally says.

Glimmer looks up to see Catra with blushing cheeks and an expression that is decisively too intense for a question she's just asked. It's almost endearing.

"What about them?" asks Glimmer, feigning ignorance to Catra's intentions, although her smile betrays her. The Force Captain

takes a moment to regain some composure, though her face still glows with bright red. Then she crosses her arms and grumbles under her breath, "I don't know why I even fucking bothered."

Glimmer doesn't even attempt to mask her grin anymore. It's quite fascinating to see Catra's entire demeanour change like that. It almost feels like she's tripped on a curtain to reveal something Glimmer clearly wasn't supposed to see.



"We didn't finish our last conversation, did we?" Catra huffs out.

"Clearly, one of crucial importance."

"Are you honestly going to act like this?" She tenses her lips in a very childish pout. "Cause I can just leave."

"Aaww, no, come on!" Glimmer laughs heartily. "I want to talk about sleepovers. I really do."

"Wow, someone's desperate," Catra mutters, but pulls up a chair, turns it around and sits on it leaning forward on its back, glaring

at Glimmer with her glowing eyes. “When was the last time you had one of those?”

Glimmer leans back on elbows, trying to remember.

“Probably… Maybe a few months ago? I’m not sure, really. Haven’t had much time for them over the past year.”

“What did you do? Besides cake theft, of course.”

“Played cards for a while, then turned in,” Glimmer takes a moment, considering something. “Oh, that’s right, you don’t know… I mean like these special cards, that you can use to play different games with-“

“I know what cards are, muffin-face.”

“Sorry,” Glimmer raises her eyebrows. “It’s just that when Adora first joined us, there were so many things she’s never even heard of…”

“That’s because she’s a square, who wouldn’t dare to break the rules, no matter how dumb they were. We didn’t all live under a rock.”

“Are you sure that’s right?” Glimmer squinted her eyes at her. “Didn’t she… oh, I don’t know… stole a skiff with you the night we found her in the woods?”

“Oh, yeah. I used to bring out her wild side, you know. Sometimes… and don’t you dare tell anyone about this…” she leans in conspiratorially. “…she’d stay up past her bedtime with me.”



Glimmer snorts and tosses a pillow at Catra, only for her to catch it mid-air.

"Now you've got rid of your arsenal, Sparkles. Big mistake," says the Horde commander with a shit-eating grin plastered on her face, lifting up to sit on the pillow.

"Oh, joy. Now my only pillow's going to smell like your butt."

"Bold of you to assume I'll be returning that anytime soon."

"Just when I think my life can't possibly suck any more, the enemy has me sleeping pillow-less."

Catra flashes her sharp teeth in a grin again, but this time a whole lot less malicious. “Okay, so… Is that what you’d normally do at your sleepovers? Play cards?”

“We also had board games… We’d play charades… Truth or dare a few times…”

“Wow. Dirty.”

“Not THAT kind of truth or dare. It was mostly questions like ‘do you still sleep with a stuffed animal’ and dares like ‘go get me a soda’.”

“I always knew princesses were absolute fucking maniacs. You guys seriously need to calm down.”

“Oh, shut up!” Glimmer laughs, kicking the air in Catra’s vague direction, now that she’s lost her only projectile weapon. “How did your sleepovers look like then?”

“Well, let’s see…” Catra fixes herself on the chair. “Depends how old we were, I guess. When we were little, we’d mostly play The Brave Force Captain and the Ugly Bloodthirsty Princess.”

“Really? How did that look like?”

“What do you mean, you and I play it constantly.”

Glimmer casually gives her the finger.

Catra beams with pride of her own joke. “Okay, okay… we’d usually fight over who gets to be the Force Captain. Then Adora would usually let me win, because otherwise I’d pout and refuse to play. We made this shitty crown and a sword out of cardboard and we would tie our blankets around like capes…”

She says all this in a warm voice, that Glimmer’s never heard from her before. “That is… seriously adorable.”

“Tell that to Lonnie. She was always so pissed at us for not letting her sleep.”

“Why didn’t you just invite her to play with you?”

Catra shrugs, looking at the floor. “I don’t know. The two of us were enough, I guess.”

She takes a moment to pull the pillow out and poke it with her claws a little.

“Anyway,” she adds. “If we were ever to play charades together, Adora and I would absolutely destroy you. We had this…”

“Special secret language,” Glimmer finishes for her. Then, seeing her bewildered expression, adds “Adora’s mentioned it only like a million times. It’s so sweet, it makes me want to puke.”

Catra goes quiet again for a long while. She stands up, eventually, and takes another stroll around the cell, hugging the pillow to her chest.

“There’s really nothing to do here, is there,” she says when she finally speaks again. “I should bring something next time.”

“Next time?” Glimmer carefully inquires.

“Unless you don’t any Horde scum coming here. I don’t have to.”

“No,” Glimmer interjects quickly. “It’s… fine.”

She smiles to herself a little. “Can I make a list of things for you to bring me?”

“Absolutely not,” Catra says, finishing her walk by hopping up to sit on the tabletop, as if the chair isn’t right there.

“Cool. So, I want a bar of lavender soap… a couple of magazines… actually, make that a gift basket…”

“The only thing you can have is this,” Catra throws the pillow back at her, but not before licking it first.

“Eeeww…” Glimmer picks it up by a corner, trying not to touch the drooled spot. “You’re disgusting.”

“Thanks, Sparkles.”

“Do you mean it about coming here again, though?”

“Oh, who knows. You certainly don’t exactly have a great track record for being able to tell when I’m bluffing.”

Glimmer thinks back to the day she’s managed to – accidentally – take Catra prisoner. Apparently her response to being kidnapped was to bluff relentlessly and annoy her captors into letting her go. It was actually a fairly effective strategy.

“That was years ago. I got better.”

“Is that so? Want to put your skills to a test and ask me something?”

“I would ask you about what’s going on on Etheria, but I assumed you don’t know anymore than I do.” She means that in a casual way, but realizes all too late how accusatory it sounds.

Catra’s ears twitch ever so slightly, but there’s really no hiding it in those terrible bright lights.

“Either that, or I’m not stupid enough to tell my enemy.”

Glimmer nods, deciding to let her have this one. She probably overstepped a boundary in their weird, fragile dynamic, so fair enough.

Although, it makes her wonder – for Catra to be this touchy about it, it must mean she’s really been side-lined by Horde Prime quite profoundly. Why else would she be wasting her time sneaking in here to talk about sleepovers of all things?

The last thing Glimmer wants, though, is to chase Catra away for good. She frantically tries to think of something that would quickly steer the conversation into more neutral areas.

"So…" she attempts. "Have you ever had a crush on Adora?"

She can instantly tell this had the desired effect of diverting Catra's attention from the previous subject, as she stares at her with a blankly shocked expression. Glimmer hasn't seen anyone blush so hard since Adora found the stache of magazines she kept under the mattress.

"What," says Catra hoarsely. She fixes her eyes on Glimmer, her tail swinging violently behind her.

"Well, I'm just saying…"

"You know, I've heard that solitary confinement can drive you insane, but honestly, I did not expect it to happen this fast."

"Come on! You always talk about her, you can't possibly blame me for thinking… And look! That time at the Princess Prom!"

"What about it? Everyone was dancing with everybody then. I even danced with you of all people, I recall."

"Right before you kidnapped me, I remember. But only a certain feline Horde scum decided to spend the night all over the big muscle lady only when Adora was paying attention."

"You think that was to make her jealous?"

"I mean, it was about as subtle as Entrapta's droids."

"And what, are you worried that I'm going to swoop in and steal your girl away?"

"My-," Glimmer stops abruptly, then turns to stare at Catra. "Oh. Oooooh."

“Wh-what?”

“Nothing. I see what you’re doing there, that’s all,” Glimmer isn’t sure if she finds this conversation or Catra’s changing expressions more amusing. “We’ve never been dating. She’s like a sister to me.”

“Pff, this isn’t even-,” Catra’s ears twitch as she freezes in a spot.

She stands up without making a sound and approaches the green door.

“What…” Glimmer attempts, only to get shushed by her.

Then she starts hearing the steps nearing too.

“He’s here to pick up your tray,” Catra whispers. “I need to go.”

“What? No, wait, you can’t just…”

“I’ll be back tomorrow. Now act natural, don’t look at me.”

As a clone appears at the end of the corridor, Glimmer sees Catra’s shape settling herself by the side of the door. It’s impressive how she manages to make herself barely visible while bathed in those lights.

The guard finally walks up and uses his hand to deactivate the door, his eyes fixed on Glimmer. With the corner of her eye, she sees Catra dashing out soundlessly, leaving the clone none the wiser.

“Your highness… Oh,” the clone says, noticing the wreckage that was left of her meal. “That is unfortunate. Allow me to get something to clean this up. We wouldn’t want our cherished guest to be uncomfortable in her room.”

He steps out, a faint smile that doesn’t reach his eyes now fading, and closes the green door. Glimmer finally lets her eyes dash to the spot where she’s last seen Catra.

She wonders if she’s truly planning on coming back.

Or whether this whole conversation was some sort of a fever dream.



Catra

Horde Prime's trophy room has a high ceiling and floors made of something Catra would guess is marble. The walls are lined with a whole variety of impressive objects, ranging from weapons that would put Adora's sword to shame, to pieces of technology which Entrapta would go insane over, all neatly draped in a choice of flags from the conquered planets. A glass display full intricately made shields is flanked by two rows of swords, spears and sceptres hung decoratively, each in its own perfectly calculated spot. Catra sees the magical staff that belongs to Sparkles among them and her stomach twists just a little.

Eventually, she swipes what looks like a deck of cards with splotches of ink on them, warily glancing at the door. She knows the chances of anyone sneaking up without her hearing it first are incredibly slim, but this place is making her paranoid. It feels simultaneously overwhelmingly modern and haunted. It reminds her of the Crystal Castle, which up until a few days ago, was the one place she disliked more than the Fright Zone.

Now this ship was another strong contender.

The cards might not be the coolest steal of her career, but at least they were easy enough to pocket – it's not like she could have hid an enormous melee weapon behind her back when passing a stray clone. Still, small acts of defiance always did wonders to relieve her frustrations, whether it was scratching out a rude word on Lonnie's locker, or fist fighting an entire bar in the Crimson Waste.

When Prime first took her onboard his ship, it felt like she was being rescued. She'd burned all of her bridges back on her home planet, the princesses hated her for destroying their kingdoms, the Horde hated her for being a bitch, Hordak hated her for sending Entrapta away – she may have very well been the most despised person on Etheria. And as much as she tried her best to

brave through everything and act like she was in control, she was the only person who knew just how much she was drowning.

Well, and Double Trouble, perhaps. They also, infuriatingly, seemed to have a good idea.

And then Horde Prime came along and whisked her away from a dead end she drove herself into. Prime gave her a clean slate and another opportunity to climb her way to the top. She instantly felt so relieved and hopeful. Maybe only a little disappointed.

Catra had never been the strongest of the bunch, but if there was one thing she was great at, it was finding her opponent's tell and using it to her advantage. That was how she could beat up thugs twice her size, give Adora such a hard time in battle, defeat Shadow Weaver, even force Hordak to give her control over the Horde. She had a talent for noticing all weaknesses from a sore ankle to a ridiculous hero complex, and she made exploiting them her very own method or survival.

But it's been days and she was yet to find a single weakness in Horde Prime.

Despite having a vaguely person-like shape, he feels more like a machine than most of the Fright Zone droids. There are no fears or needs to be satisfied, only a singular higher purpose he pursues without much of an emotional response. There is no way for Catra to manipulate someone like that. She can't even think of a way to be of use to someone like that.

And if that is the case, then why is he even keeping her here?

He asked her for nothing since their meeting, his every whim fulfilled by an army of fully disposable clones that act as extensions of himself. No way she can compete with this level of nepotism. There are plenty of chambers she has no access to, including most of Etheria's surveillance. Her chamber is no different than Glimmer's, save for the force field doors keeping her inside. She's not naïve and knows that at this point she's just as

much of a prisoner as Sparkles, yet for the life of her, she can't understand to what purpose.

It's frustrating, and confusing, and quite exhausting.

And honestly, she just can't bring herself to care much anymore. If he wants her dead, fine – she can't exactly stop him in any meaningful way. And it's not like there is anyone else who would care whether she lives or not. It's just so annoying not knowing what he plans for her, if anything at all.

Oh, and that little trick he tried to pull on her, acting like she still cares about Adora? As if.

There is very little she can do to get back at him, though. So she takes pleasures in exacting those little acts of revenge – marking the walls with her claws. Stealing some useless crap. Sneaking into Glimmer's cell. Just because she was told not to, because, whatever. She doesn't care.

The winding maze of identical corridors eventually lead Catra to the vicinity of the kitchens, where she finds a good spot to watch the doors without being seen. At least she's managed to discover that Prime does not, in fact, see everything, but only the things his clones can see. And since their hearing is much worse than hers, sneaking around them isn't much of a challenge - she's no stranger to avoiding security cameras.

Her timing is immaculate, she barely manages to take a seat before a clone walks out of the kitchens carrying a tray of food for Glimmer. She waits for him to walk past her hiding spot, then proceeds to follow in his footsteps all the way up to the holding cell, where she takes her place by the side of the huge green door. The guard's gaze is fixed on their pink prisoner, sitting on her bed as usual, dangling her chubby legs over the edge. He pays absolutely no attention to Catra slipping inside the moment the doors disappear, like a shadow. He places the tray on the floor, bows to Glimmer, steps back. And soon, the force field resumes

it’s low buzz and takes a lime tingle again. Yes again, she’s in, with Prime none the wiser.

She waits for the clone to leave, before daring to make a sound.

”Hey, Sparkles,” she makes herself known and smiles triumphantly when Glimmer gasps and jolts up.

”Oh, for the love of—… do you always have to do that?” she turns around and places hands on her hips, trying her best to look absolutely furious. ”It wasn’t funny the first time!”

”Oh, but it was. And it will be just as funny the third time,” Catra leaps onto the tabletop, where she pulls up her legs to hug them. “Why are you being so jumpy, anyway? You knew I’d be coming.”

“I wasn’t sure you meant it,” Glimmer grumbles, picking the food tray off the floor. “And get your smelly feet off, this is where I eat!”

“Whatcha got this time?”

“Eh… Some sort sort of… crackers? I hope?”

Catra eyes the tray curiously, then reaches out to steal one off the queen’s plate.

“Better you than me,” Glimmer sighs, placing the tray on the table next to Catra.

“Come on. If there’s one thing you can be certain of, it’s that no one here is going to poison you,” Catra says before taking a bite. “Jufft… Ffink about it. If Prime wanted to kill you, he’d have done that already. And there’s like a million easier ways to do it.”

“Well, yaaaay, I guess,” Glimmer slides down into the chair, watching Catra stuff her face with another mouthful of maybe-crackers from a bowl. “Don’t they feed you out there at all? Is that why you came here, to steal my food?”

“Oh, right!” Catra claps her hands, having swallowed the last of her bite. “I got something.” She pulls the deck of cards out of her pockets and ceremoniously places them in front of Glimmer, who squints her eyes at them.

“What are these?”

Catra sighs. “Well, you see, sometimes you have these special cards, and you can use them to play…”

Glimmer throws some of the bowl’s contents at her.

“I meant, none of these are similar to one another. And they look like someone’s just spilled a whole lot of ink into their drawer and had to toss them out. How do we play them?”

Catra lets out another sigh. At this rate her lungs will likely run out of air soon. “So sorry I risked my life to steal them from Prime’s trophy room in the heist of the century and didn’t linger behind to check if these came with any instructions, your majesty.”

“You did that for me?” Glimmer grins at her. “Aww, babe. You should have just asked me to dinner…”

“It wasn’t for you, princess.”

“Just so you know, lilac flowers are my favourites and I’ve always dreamt of a wedding in spring…”

“Ugh, I hate you so much!” Catra attempts to push Glimmer off the chair as she laughs hysterically at her own joke.

For a moment, Catra feels a small sting of embarrassment for feeling this carefree around her. She still hates Glimmer, of course she does - how can she not hate someone who is basically the antithesis to her? Even the way she looks is all soft curves and pink pastels and cute glitter and Catra, well, let’s just say one of the older cadets once said she looks like someone tried to draw a person and suffered a seizure with a pencil still in their hand - he’s earned a permanent scar for that. Catra was the chief commander

of the Horde back on Etheria, and Sparkles is the queen of Bright-fucking-Moon. The two of them hanging out together like it's nothing would almost be funny, if it wasn't so thoroughly sad for the both of them.

But the other, bigger part of Catra just can't bring itself to care anymore. The quick rhythm of banter between them brings her a soothing sense of familiarity. It's enjoyable, so, why not? There's no reputation or status she even has left that this would destroy. She certainly doesn't care what Glimmer thinks of her of all people. Realistically, the chances of the both of them getting murdered by Prime at some point are fairly high. They might as well play cards and throw crackers at each other.

Still, Catra is very much determined that she will never like the person who took Adora away from her.

Glimmer takes the cards and settles down on the bed, spreading them all around herself and studying each one with an intense expression.

"Where do you think he got these from?" she asks.

"Dunno," Catra slides down gracefully to sit crossed-legged beside her. "Some planet he's blown up into bits ages ago, I presume."

"Kind of a morbid collection he's got there, doesn't he?" Glimmer says grimly, sliding cards over the floor to set them in a neat row. "Anyway, it doesn't look like we can play any game I know with those. The backs don't even look anything like each other."

"You might lack creativity, Sparkles."

"Oh, yeah? Fine, then. Here – tell me what this one reminds you of?" She picks up a card and shoves it into Catra's face.

"Uh," Catra says in response. She takes the card from Glimmer's hand and analyses the shape. "Okay, um… a cloud."

The queen of Bright Moon makes a long, loud fart noise. “And you say I lack creativity? I’d honestly struggle to think of an answer that’s lamer than this.” She hands her another card. “Try again.”

At this point Catra stops counting how many times she’s sighed since entering this cell. “Fine. Ugh. Let’s see…” She pauses, pursuing her lips. “Looks like… a dragon, flying through the sky, and blowing fire out of his ass.”

She points out the latter in the picture to prove her point. Glimmer scratches her chin, pensive. “Unexpected, cool, and a little disgusting. Just like you. I will accept this answer.”

“I’m going to murder you.”

“You’re welcome to try, Horde scum. I thought this looked like a cake someone took a bite out of.”

“You must be on some serious sugar withdrawal, huh?”

“I’m literally dying here.”

Catra reaches to grab a handful of crackers and puts her hand up to Glimmer’s mouth. “Here, this should lessen the pain.”

“I’m not a horse,” she attempts to smack Catra’s hand away, as she laughs and spills the crackers all over the floor. “Pick another one, you weirdo.”

“Isn’t it supposed to be your turn?” Catra asks, but chooses a card anyway. “Oh. Hmm.”

“What is it?”

“Uh, nothing.”

“What?”

“Nothing, I’m thinking.”

“You’ve already thought of something, so tell me.”

“Well…” Catra hesitates. “I did think of something, but I shouldn’t say it with minors present.”

“I see no minors here.” Whether consciously or not, Glimmer straightens her back, as if trying to look taller.

“How old are you?”

“Turned eighteen recently.”

“You’re practically a fetus then.”

“Oh really, how old are you, like *twenty*?” she huffs, face turning just a little more red than pink.

“Twenty-one. Same as Adora.”

“Yeah, you’re practically grandmothers. Tell me what you see.”

Catra slides herself up closer to show Glimmer the card.

“See this oval shape here… and then these two circles…” she points out each one with her claw. “And then this thing around it?”

“Yeah, it looks like some sort of a tower, what about-…” Glimmer stops abruptly, as red spills on her cheeks. “Uh, *Catra*!”

“You insisted!” Catra laughs, as she gets pushed down and lands on the floor.

“*Dirty*.”

“Yeah, well, that’s me.”

“It *is* you, alright.”

“Okay, okay,” Catra reaches out to point at another card, inexplicably getting invested in the game. “Now you. Go.”

It doesn't take long for Glimmer to come up with an answer. "Oh, I know, it's like… the top of this ship! You know, the one we're on?"

"The Velvet Glove?"

"The… I'm sorry. What were those words that just left your mouth now?"

"The Velvet. Glove," Catra repeats, through chuckling already.

"You're joking. I don't believe this is what it's called."

"I swear it is."

"And you know it sounds like a… a euphemism for…"

"Oh, I do."

"And does Horde Prime?..."

"I don't think so, no."

They share a look, then burst out laughing in unison. When Glimmer squeezes Catra's shoulder briefly, she feels a flash of warmth in her stomach that she doubts has anything to do with the possibility of crackers being poisoned.


And does Horde Prime?...
I don't think so, no.
AHAHAHAH

“I can’t tell which is worse. The rebellion getting our asses kicked by someone who named their ship ‘The Velvet Glove’, or me being prison buddies with someone who sees genitalia in spilled ink onboard of it.” Glimmer lunges herself on the bed, all giggly.

“Prison buddies?” Catra tries to settle down, leaning on Glimmer’s knees, though her face is still split in a grin. “I’m one of your captors, remember?”

“Well, yeah. I mean, that’s what you’re *saying*.” Glimmer smiles at her, more friendly than ever.

But Catra lifts herself up, suddenly feeling all the humour evaporating from her.

“That’s because I am,” she says, voice strained at the edges.



"Uh, sure, but…"

"What, do you think I'm being held prisoner here?" she can hear her own voice rising in pitch.

Glimmer sits up, expression blankly perplexed. Her mouth opens and closes a few times soundlessly.

“I’m…” she stutters out, rubbing her lower lip in a self-soothing gesture. “Well, uh. Kind of. Aren’t you?”

“Of course I’m not,” Catra balls the fists at her sides. The warmth is back, spilling all over her insides, though it’s nothing like the comforting excitement she’s felt barely seconds ago. “I work for Horde Prime. I *wanted* to be here.”

“Okay, I know,” Glimmer says carefully, slumping forward a little. “But… Well, it’s just that… There’s been a bit of a development, right?”

“What are you talking about?”

“I mean… You know!” she waves her arms around in frustration. “All of this? Do I really need to say it?”

She doesn’t. She really doesn’t, because Catra knows what she means perfectly well. But she feels it coming again, this hot ball of rage in her chest that’s about to blow up again, because it’s one thing for her to know how screwed she is, and another for this pink, carefree, sparkly, entitled little princess to have the nerve to point it out to her.

Glimmer plants her palms flat on the bed.

“You said you were going to rise to the top again at Prime’s side, right? But you know that’s just not going to happen,” she says. “Prime isn’t the kind of person who needs anyone by his side. You’ve seen how he’s dealt with Hordak already! This isn’t even about loyalty or usefulness with him anymore, he’ll get rid of anything and anyone that he cannot completely and fully control, and you weren’t exactly someone who liked to follow orders to begin with, were you?”

Every word she says is painfully correct and Catra absolutely can’t stand it. She feels her tail bushing up and doesn’t even bother hiding it.

“So what the hell do you suppose he’s keeping me in here for? Fucking decoration?” she slices her hand through the air. “Hordak couldn’t even take Etheria when the Rebellion was at its weakest. I was the one who took over and conquered Etheria for Prime. If it weren’t for me, he’d never even know we existed!”

“Oh, screw that! Don’t pretend you’ve done that for him, or even the Horde for that matter!” Glimmer finally stands up in a wide stance. “You wanna know what he’s keeping you in here for? Isn’t it obvious?”

“I swear, if you say her name right now, I’m going to scratch your face bloody. I’m already dangerously close.”

“Well, go ahead then! Might make you feel better! Maybe once you’ll bleed me out, you’ll calm down enough to comprehend that you’re not a Horde commander, you’re not even a soldier anymore, because the Horde as it was just doesn’t exist anymore. Prime is going to wipe out the Fright Zone and everyone in it along with the whole planet without giving it a second thought. Go ahead. Tell me I’m wrong.”

“Fuck you,” Catra spits.

“Yeah, fuck me. I’m sure it’s so much easier to rip the world apart, destroy our planet, kill my mother, or murder the only person who’s ever loved you than to simply admit that you might have been wrong!” Glimmer jabs her finger at Catra’s chest.



Before Catra can think of a retort, her ear twitches unwillingly towards a soft sound of footsteps in the distance – the guard coming to pick up Glimmer's tray.

Without a word, Catra walks up to her spot by the door, struggling to keep her hands from shaking. As the clone comes in to collect the tray, she wonders for a moment if Glimmer is about to expose her, but she says nothing, just watching the entire scene unfold with lips pursed tightly.

Once the green door reappears again, Catra stays in the shadow, breathless, for just enough to cast one last hateful look towards the cell. She realizes they're two small drips of blood on the floor – she's been pressing claws into her palms too strongly.

The second the clone’s footsteps fade in the corridor, she walks away without looking back, leaving Glimmer alone in the cell, cards still spilled out on her bed.



Glimmer

It's been days since Catra furiously walked out of the holding cell and yet, for some reason, Glimmer cannot stop thinking about their fight.

She's tried, of course, but there is very little to distract herself with. She walks around the cell, studies the floor pattern, traces her finger over the table, all to stay away from those stupid cards, hidden underneath the mattress. But eventually, her thoughts always drag her back to Catra, standing stiff with her arms crossed, tail swinging, ugly green light flickering on her furious face that carefully conceals fear. Glimmer is angry for letting herself be so preoccupied with it – it's not like she hasn't had fights with Catra before, in fact, this was probably the least deadly one they've ever had so far. So what's different now? Is it just because there is literally nothing to do but mull it over? Or is it because in some bizarre, almost surreal way, for a brief moment it felt like the two of them had a shot at being something akin to friends?

Glimmer thinks, as she paces back and forth between the two walls, the dumbest thing about this is that Catra is literally the last person she'd ever want to be friends with. She vividly remembers Adora, having freshly joined the rebellion, talking about the Horde so solemnly, like she was embarrassed of it, but her tone would always change when she mentioned Catra. Her entire face would light up as she recounted all the mischief the two of them were up to, all the fond memories of them hiding up on their "roof spot", all the times Catra's done something cool or funny or otherwise amazing. "Oh, this reminds me of the time Catra and I were sitting up in my bed and talking…" this, and "I can't wait for you guys to meet Catra, she's the most clever and hilarious person ever…" that, with a side of "Look, I just know she's not a bad person, she's bound to join us soon enough…". Glimmer and Bow even had to develop a new type of conspicuous stare between them to use whenever Adora mentioned Catra unprompted yet again.

And then, she actually met Catra.

The cognitive dissonance was staggering, to say the least. It's not that she was counting on the Horde's Force Captain to actually greet her with open arms, but she expected her to be at least a little bit similar to how Adora's described her. Just 5% similar, she wasn't being demanding. But in the end, a ruthless, spiteful and selfish brat, who'd burn the world down just to annoy Adora, was all there was. Glimmer couldn't see even the slightest glimpse of a person her friend had described, and the more encounters they've had, the more certain she was of her judgement.

Over time, Adora spoke of Catra less and less often. This past year, she'd barely mentioned her and appeared to visibly tense up every time someone would as much as mention her former best friend. It seemed like even she's realized that Catra is someone absolutely beyond anyone's reach. She was evil, full stop.

But then, the past week happened.

There was nothing utterly worldview-shattering about their recent encounters, exactly, and nothing that couldn't also be explained by Catra being shelved by Prime and bored beyond herself. But beneath it all, there was… something. Glimmer finally saw it, that tiny little glimpse of the smart, determined and mischievous girl Adora's always been talking about. Turns out she wasn't dead or non-existent after all and there was something fascinating about it. Something… hopeful.

And so Glimmer spends hours staring at the ceiling, replaying their fight in her head, imagining all the possible scripts for what she should have said. She's came up with some killer arguments for the next time she sees her, really. Shame she doesn't have anything to write them down with – she's a big fan of the "if you hate Adora so much, why are you so obsessed with her?" one, but phrasing needs a bit of work.

It would be great to have Bow here - if only to have him confirm that she was actually fully in the right throughout the argument

and it was only Catra who needed to apologize. Somehow, as days went by, Glimmer began losing a lot of her confidence in that.

She finds herself scanning the whole cell every time a guard brings food. Once, she even felt compelled to check under the bed, as if Catra would try to jump-scare her again in retaliation. But she hasn't shown up once, not even to gawk at her through the door and gloat. It's been several days and Glimmer found herself slowly losing hope that Catra would ever show up again.

And then one day, as she sits on the bed, watching a clone walk away with an empty tray, she looks up to have her gaze met by a pair of glowing eyes in a bushy-haired, triangle-eared shape by the door.

Catra doesn't say anything at first, only locks eyes with Glimmer, expression unreadable. They stare each other down for what feels like several minutes.



"You're here," Glimmer says eventually. She suddenly forgets every single witty line she's been rehearsing.

Catra just nods, not taking her eyes off of her. Another few tense seconds pass.

“Did you just come here to stare at me?” Glimmer asks, realizing her eyes are starting to water. She is yet to see Catra blink even once.

Catra takes her time. “I brought this,” she finally shifts and Glimmer notices her hand is curled around the neck of a large glass bottle.

Glimmer’s eyes squint. “Is that..?”

“Booze. I think. It smells like it,” Catra says, uncorking the bottle with ease using her claws. “Tastes like booze too. And yes, I tried it and I lived.”

They lapse into silence again. Glimmer realizes one of her knees started bouncing impatiently and wills it to stop.

“So… do you want to share?” she asks, trying to sound casual.

“Do you?”

“Catra,” Glimmer sighs. “Look, about what I said-“

“I also brought some pens and paper,” Catra interrupts. “Figured we might think of something to do with them. Keep the score, if nothing else.”

“Okay, but-“

“No,” Catra says firmly, setting the bottle on the table with a loud clink. “We’re not continuing that conversation.”

Glimmer is already sick of having to look up so much, so she stands up. She really hates that inch Catra has on her. “We can’t just pretend like we didn’t argue!”

“Sure, we can. I can stay and we can pass some time getting wasted and doing some dumb shit. Or you can tell me to leave and I will.”

“You can’t leave, the door’s locked,” Glimmer puffs her cheeks out. “And it’s going to be a few hours before any guards come here again, they just took the tray back.”

“I can call out for them and turn myself in,” Catra shrugs. “You probably won’t see me again, but then again, that’s the idea.”

She sits herself on the table again, legs swinging wide apart. Damn, she’s annoying.

For a moment, Glimmer considers her options – she doesn’t like leaving the fight unresolved, especially when she feels like she’s owed an apology. Last year she’s had her fair share of unfinished arguments that just built up on top of each other until exploding in a disaster. And that was with *Adora*, one of the most reasonable people she knows.

But on the other hand, it’s possible that simply returning here was as far as Catra was willing to go right now. She was already stretching the limits of her pride and stubbornness and Glimmer wouldn’t put it past her to really turn herself in to avoid a tough conversation. She’d rather not push it too much.

Not that she cares all that much what happens to Catra, but it felt just a little lighter to have some company here. Even at the cost of pausing an argument.

Glimmer reaches for the bottle and, without hesitation, takes a hearty swig. It’s rich and sweet, reminds her of the red wine she once tried in secret in the Bright Moon cellars.

“That should make it easier to deal with your sorry ass, at least,” she grumbles and feels an odd sense of relief seeing Catra finally crack a smile, even if she gives her the finger as she does.

They end up seating themselves behind the bed, so that it hides them from the outside view, playing several rounds of card games, which they both make up as they go. Their creativity is directly proportional to the amount of alcohol they consume and soon enough the game rules grow too elaborate to keep track of.

Glimmer is already plenty giddy when she slaps both hands on her knees to yell out: "A DRINKING GAME!"

"Isn't this what we were doing this whole time?" Catra asks, leaning against the bed, laughing and clutching the bottle to her chest. "We're drinking and playing a game?"

"No, no, but like… Let's put some competition into it!" Glimmer hears herself half-yelling. "We can play… two truths and a lie. Or, assumptions!" She points a finger at Catra excitedly.

"What the hell is assumptions?" Catra can clearly hold her liquor a little better, but a little swaying to the side betrays her almost as much as giggling.

"We make assumptions about each other, duuuh," Glimmer waves her hands impatiently. "If we get it wrong, we drink, if we get it right, the other one drinks."

"That's a terrible idea! We can just lie, or, I can just use what Double Trouble told me about you or, you can use what Adora told you about me. If she told you anything," Catra adds quickly.

"We'll just… promise not to. If you don't want to tell me something, just say so. Then… we both drink."

"We're going to run out of this very quickly." She lifts the bottle, where the liquid still splashes in the bottom half.

"Then you'll go get another one!" Glimmer decides.

"Pff," Catra huffs. "Fine. But just so you know, I'm about to be assuming some insanely personal stuff. None of the 'your favourite colour is pink' bullshit."

“HA! It’s purple! Drink up!”

“I said, none of that-“

“Drink up, drink up, drink u-“ Glimmer nearly falls over, when Catra slaps her mouth shut. She promptly decides to slobber all over it.

“Eeewww… You’re gross.” Catra says, wiping her hand over leggings. “And that’s not an assumption, that’s an assessment.”

Glimmer extends her legs and takes a deep breath, forcing her gaze to bring Catra into focus.

“Alright, alright...” she pierces her with her gaze, as if that were to help her deduction. “You… are… into… women.”

Catra throws her head back and groans. “You might have as well said ‘you have a tail’.”

“Ha! So I’m right?”

“It’s obvious!”

“A win’s a win!” Glimmer triumphantly gestures at the bottle and Catra takes a dignified sip. “Hey, if you were to pick one princess to have a fling with… Except Adora, cause of your history, and me, cause I’d smoke everyone out, obviously. Who would that be?”

“Is that a part of the game?”

“It’s a different game. That I made up just now.”

Catra makes a wistful face. “Maybe the water princess. I think there is something hot about the way she fucking hates me.”

“You think that sets her apart from the others?”

“Oh, screw you.”

“I thought you’d pick Scorpia for sure.”

“You thought wrong. What’s your pick, then?”

“I’m not sure it’s ethical for me to make that choice. They’re my subordinates.”

“Yeah, yeah..?” Catra flicks her wrist dismissively.

“Maybe… Netossa. She’s bossy, competitive and hot. I think this would be… quite an experience.”

“Just say you actually want me so bad.”

“In your dreams, Horde scum.” Glimmer blows her a kiss.

“Okay, my turn,” Catra says, wiping her mouth with the back of her hand. “You have the hots for your bestie.”

Glimmer feels a wave of warmth creeping up her face that has nothing to do with the alcohol. She straightens her back, then reaches out to take a swig. When she looks again, she finds Catra watching her wide-eyed and bemused.

“I’m not ashamed of it,” Glimmer states proudly. “Why would I be? He’s a babe.”

“Never thought I’d hear someone who makes arrows that turn into… Shoes, or, whatever, called a ‘babe’.”

“Am I not full of surprises?”

“Did you tell him?”

“Not yet.”

“So you’d want to?”

“I guess?” Glimmer sighs, hugging the bottle. “I don’t know. He might hate me a little bit now.”

“Oh, please. You fucked up the world like, once. I’m sure you’ll just kiss and make up.”

“Eh,” Glimmer feels the familiar anxiousness hovering somewhere around her stomach. Like in all those sleepless nights, when she’s tossing and turning, rotating between worrying that Bow might be dead and that he might never forgive her. “What if we won’t, though?”

“Huh?”

“I mean… He was so angry with me. I was terrible to him. And Adora. And what if I never see them again?” she takes a sip unprompted, in an attempt to calm herself down, but it seems to have an opposite effect.

“You will…”

“But what I won’t? What if they die? What if I die here? And I never get to tell them how sorry I am, and-“

“Hey. Hey,” Catra takes the bottle out of her hands and places it on the floor. She looks hazy, and Glimmer notices there must be tears in her eyes. “Of course you will.”

She kneels next to her and puts her hand on Glimmer’s back, somewhat stiffly. After a moment, she clears her throat.

“You know… I have no doubt that those two dorks are on their way to rescue you right now,” she says, awkwardly stroking her shoulder. “They’re going to bust in here, break the doors down, kick my ass and carry you out bridal-style.”

Glimmer bursts out laughing and wipes her eyes aggressively.

“You’re so dumb…” she chuckles.



"I'm telling you, it's a guarantee."

"And so drunk."

"Not nearly drunk enough for this. But I'm right, you'll see."

Her hand feels soft and Glimmer realizes she's retracted her claws.

"Thanks," Glimmer sniffs loudly. "Do you think we can skip the kicking-your-ass part this time, though?"

"Come on, you gotta let Adora have some fun. She's like a dog that needs to tire out sometimes."

"She can take up jogging then. And you can just, you know, come back with us."

Catra's mouth visibly tenses, but she doesn't seem as furious as Glimmer would expect her to.

"Come on. I'm serious," Glimmer sits up and grabs her shoulders.

"Sparkles-"

"No, come *on*," she shakes her head in an attempt to sharpen her focus. "Okay, so, look. Here's an assumption – you still care about Adora. And she cares about you, too. Just… come with us."

Catra shakes her head, stubbornly avoiding her gaze.

"Catra. Please, just… What is it with you two? I wanna hear it."

"Hasn't Adora told you about it already?"

"I wanna hear it from you. I want to… understand. What happened. Come on."

Catra sighs, then shifts herself to lean her back against the bed next to Glimmer, their shoulders touching. She looks up to the ceiling and ponders in silence for a long moment, her finger tracing the bottle's opening.

"Imagine… you have nobody," she finally says, voice coloured with an emotion Glimmer has yet to identify. "Except for this one person, who inexplicably cares about you. And the same person also happens to be taking everything away from you – the attention, the recognition, the love… And you love them, but you also hate them a little bit. And they love you, but they always love the place that's hurting you and the sense of duty that comes along with it a little bit more. And it's great, and it sucks, and it's complicated, but it works, because as long as they choose their responsibility over everything else, they'll stay here, with you, and it means you're safe."

There is visible tension at her mouth, as she swallows thickly. Glimmer glances at her, fascinated, but dares not move.

“And then one day they just… leave. All along you thought that if you can’t compete with this higher purpose they had, nothing else can. But it turns out it wasn’t important after all, but what made them realize this wasn’t a lifetime with you, it was… a few hours with some random kids they met in a forest.”

She sighs again, and lifts the bottle up to her lips, gulping down the remainder of the liquor. Glimmer doesn’t speak for a while, just presses their shoulders togethers.

“She wanted you to come with her, though,” her voice is very quiet.

“As an afterthought. A piece of luggage she left behind that had no place in her new life,” Catra says. She doesn’t move away, it feels like she’s pressing against Glimmer just as hard.

“I don’t think she saw you that way. I think… she just didn’t know how you felt.”

Catra exhales sharply. “Yeah, no shit,” she quickly rubs her freckled nose. “So, uh, guess it’s my turn again, huh?”



“We’re out of alcohol,” Glimmer points out.

“We’ll do… push-ups, then. Whatever,” she angrily rubs her nose again. “Here’s an assumption: you really, really fucking hate me and you wouldn’t talk to me if you weren’t absolutely desperate.”

Glimmer blinks quickly.

“How… how many push-ups, then?” she asks, slanting a look at her.

“Let’s say, five. I don’t want to kill you here,” Catra poignantly glances at Glimmer’s arms.

“Well then,” Glimmer shifts herself to face her. “You better get moving, Horde scum.”

Catra looks at her, eyebrows raised.

“I said what I said,” Glimmer straightens her back and places fists on her hips. “Chop, chop.”

“Didn’t you say we’re supposed to be honest?”

“Well, I am,” Glimmer pouts. “I don’t know. Call me crazy, but against all odds… I don’t actually hate you as much anymore.”

“I’m truly touched.”

“Get on the floor.”

“Woah, buy me a dinner first.”

Glimmer laughs and elbows her. She sees the corners of Catra’s lip curling upwards. “For the record, I actually hate you a little less, too.”

“Okay, actually, wait,” Glimmer raises her hands abruptly. “I got one, that I’m pretty sure I’m right about, so might as well let you get done with all the push-ups at once,” she clears her throat. “You. Had a thing. With Scorpia.”

“Define ‘thing’.”

“Let’s say… you kissed.”

They stare each other down for a few seconds, before Catra rolls her eyes and stands up to stretch.

“I take that back. I actually hate you.”

Then she gets back down and does the push-ups.



Catra

Chapter Notes

Thic chapter's cover art was made by the lovely and amazing mariatries!



“Okay - kiss, marry, kill – me, Bow and Adora?” Glimmer asks, voice very serious.

She’s sitting on the bed, hovering over Catra’s head and playing with her hair. It’s not entirely unpleasant.

“Hm…” Catra considers the question, not taking her eyes off the sheet of paper she’s propping up with her knee to idly doodle on.

“Oh, wait. All three are just a Tuesday for you and Adora,” Glimmer snorts with laughter. Catra slants a look at her to see the queen beaming with joy at her own lame joke.

“I hope we really make it back to Etheria,” Catra says, getting back to her drawing. “When that happens, I’m going to disappear.

Get off the grid completely."

"How so?" Glimmer returns to braiding Catra's hair, still giggling.

"No one will know where I am," Catra muses. "Eventually people will forget my existence. *You* will forget – you will have nothing but a vague memory of me completely owning you at checkers back in prison."

"Well, I *might* just also remember you leading the Horde and kidnapping me, perhaps."

"Oh but you won't. And stop interrupting."

"Sorry," she pulls on Catra's hair lightly.

"And then one day, when you truly don't see it coming," Catra carries on. "I will enter Bright Moon in disguise. I will get past your guards and infiltrate the castle. I will sneak into the queen's chambers."

She turns to face her.

"…and then I'll piss on everything you own."

Glimmer pushes her away, laughing.

"You are seriously the *worst*!"

"Thanks," Catra says, feeling a small burst of warmth around her chest, which she decides not to think much about right now.

Sneaking into the cell and visiting Glimmer has become a part of her routine at this point. Every day she'd wander around the ship, finding various objects they can possibly play with, snack on or get drunk on, then take them to the queen's prison cell, where they'd spend the better part of the day enjoying the stolen goods.

Although Catra would much rather down another bottle of the wine-like beverage than examine her own feelings about it, she

has to admit the entire experience is quite… liberating.

Ever since the day she got promoted to Force Captain, it felt like she's spent nearly every waking moment working. And then, whenever she wasn't working, she was thinking about work, endlessly going over plans and schemes in her head, point by point, as if hoping to keep the Horde running smoothly with her mind alone. One time Scorpia practically dragged her to have a picnic with her and Entrapta – Catra spent the entire time checking her tablet for weaponry supplies stats, occasionally lifting her head if someone happened to say the word "Adora". She can't quite remember the last time she just let herself pass the time in such a completely unproductive way and didn't feel any gut-wrenching guilt over it.

It was probably the night she and Adora stole that skiff.

And now, with Prime apparently having absolutely no use in her whether in life or death, Catra truly finds herself out of work. There is nothing to do, nothing to plan, nothing to obsessively stress over, and, as Double Trouble have pointed out ever so kindly, no one left that would even care about what she's up to.

So she ends up getting her hair braided by one of the strongest contenders for the title of her least favourite person. The absurdity of the situation is one of those things that doesn't seem to wear off.

Although, maybe Sparkles has managed to move down a few ranks over the past days.

"There!" Glimmer throws something over Catra's shoulder and she realizes it's her own hair. "You actually look good."

"I appreciate the bare minimum of sarcasm in your voice." Catra says, already starting to untangle the braid.

"Aaaww, of course you ruined it," Glimmer pouts. "And I wasn't being sarcastic, it looked good, like, you finally didn't have that

perpetual ominous shadow over your face. Although now that I've said it, I realize that was probably the whole point."

Catra responds by pointing finger guns at her.

"If you came to Bright Moon, I would give you *such* a makeover," Glimmer sighs, throwing herself onto bed with a soft thump.

"That's why I never come over. That is the only reason."

"I thought you said you were going to come over and piss on my stuff."

"Oh, yeah. Just this once. We'll have a great pissing, slash, makeover session."

"So, a pissing over."

This is so ridiculous that Catra just can't help throwing her head back in laughter. She turns around again, stretching to poke Glimmer in the ribs.

"You're *such* an id-…" she stops herself mid-word and feigns a coughing fit into her elbow instead.

"You're okay?" Glimmer rolls onto her belly and slaps her between shoulder blades a few times. "Darn, here I was, already starting to hope you *don't* die on me here."

Catra coughs one more time for good measure. "I'm fine."

"Good. I'd have a hard time explaining your corpse to Prime," Glimmer grins at her. "Was that an allergic reaction to your hair not looking like you've been sticking forks into sockets?"

"I have every right to look like this, then. You know how many times Shadow Weaver's zapped me when I was a kid?"

Glimmer sits up quickly, her tone changing instantly. "Oh shit. I'm sorry."

Catra shrugs. Few days prior, they've had some alcohol again and spent the entire night talking about her. Catra wasn't too shocked to learn that Glimmer's father had been one of the first of Shadow Weaver's protegees, or that she seemed to have set her sights on the daughter next. She's always been an absolute delight to those she could manipulate into doing her bidding and a nightmare to those she didn't find immediately useful. What was surprising, though, was hearing that Adora actually spoke against her, for once. She was always a little slow on the uptake, but when it came to Shadow Weaver, Catra was pretty certain Adora would never internalize how evil she actually was. Way too prove her wrong, some three years after it would have been actually useful, huh.

She doesn't know why, but telling Glimmer about Shadow Weaver doesn't feel as uncomfortable as it should. Maybe it's just how they are now. Or maybe their relationship has become this unfiltered because on some level, Catra doesn't think it's likely for both of them to leave this ship alive and she just doesn't say it aloud for not wanting to upset her only companion about it.

"I'm fine."

"You're sure?" Glimmer puts a hand on Catra's shoulder. Catra can't see her face, but she just knows she has this infuriatingly concerned expression. It reminds her way too much of Adora.

"Yes, Sparkles. Sometimes I say disturbing shit casually just to throw you off your game a little."

Glimmer sits up straight behind her.

"I knew it!"

"Next time we have a showdown, I'm going to spend an inordinate amount of time telling you about my sad childhood and the story behind my mask."

"Do you mean the one you're wearing right now… or the one you put on in front of everybody, so no one can see the real you?"

Catra feels compelled to groan loudly while sinking onto the floor completely. Glimmer grins at her, hovering over from the bed.

"For real, with all your tiara hate, why are you wearing this?" she taps her nails quickly over Catra's masked forehead.

"It's not a tiara."

"It sure looks a whole lot like one."

"It's not—It works as a hairband, okay. I don't have Adora's magical hair that glows and levitates behind her without any wind blowing necessary."

"Why not just tie your hair back?"

"Because this… looks… better," Catra says, fixing the mask on her face. Glimmer tilts a completely unconvinced look at her. "…and maybe I don't like my hairline very much." Catra adds in a rush.

Glimmer presses the back of her hand against her mouth to stifle a laugh in a less-than-subtle way.

"Oh*, shut up*!" Catra covers her face with her palms, half-convinced that Glimmer is about to forcefully rip her mask off, but nothing of the sort happens.

"And here I was, thinking you must have accidentally glued it to your face once and now you're just playing it cool."

"Shut. Your entire face. Up," Catra sits up and tries to grab a pillow, but Glimmer snatches it out of her reach. "Ugh, look. I used to have bangs, but they got in my eyes during training. One day Shadow Weaver threatened to shave my head unless I pulled my hair back, and this…" she points at her mask. "…was the only option that didn't make me look like a complete dweeb."

"Weeeeell…"

Catra stretches her hands, poignantly showing her claws off.

“Come on, I’m kidding!” Glimmer shuffles on the bed to sit up. Clearly, she likes feeling taller. “And was this one of those times? When you say some sad things to throw me off?”

“Perhaps.”

“Booo. Get some new material!” she swings a pillow in her direction. “But for the record, that sounds horrible, I’m sorry, and I hope Shadow Weaver chokes on a moldy piece of toast.”

“Why, thank you, princess.”

“Also, I’m pretty decent at cutting hair. I can give you your bangs back if you want.”

“Trying to set up a hair salon onboard of the Velvet Glove, I see? Do you even have scissors here?”

“Well, I actually left them on my dressing table back in Bright Moon.”

“Your…” Catra lifts her eyes up. “Oh. Oooh, you sneaky little shit. Did you really just..?”

The corners of Glimmer’s lips turn slightly upward, by way of admission.

In response, Catra lightly punches her arm. “You really thought you were being smooth, huh? Sure, I’ll be joining your dumb rebellion for a haircut. If only Adora thought of that earlier.”

“If only…” Glimmer sighs, then yawns. “Well, since it doesn’t look like we’re going anywhere soon, I still have plenty of time to work on you. We’ll get there, eventually.”

Catra gently closes her eyes for a second to collect her patience, but decides not to bother arguing about that.

“Here,” she finally hands Glimmer a piece of paper with a drawing she’s been working on.

Glimmer grabs it excitedly, nearly ripping the page in half, to look at a little more than a stick figure of herself. "Oooh… Wow, this is amazing!"

"Pff, please," Catra thinks that Glimmer has either never seen any drawing in her life before, or must be trying really hard to butter her up. She used to like drawing and doodled a lot in her days as a cadet, but it was one of those things the Horde could never find a use for, so it was discouraged. She never got any good at it.

"I mean it! I… I look so powerful."

"I know!" Catra lifts herself up to sit by her. "Here, I'll add an autograph. One day it will be worth millions."

"Or," Glimmer says, lifting the paper out of Catra's reach. "Get another sheet and draw Bow next!"

"I don't have a persistent image of him in my brain. I need a reference."

"Who else can you draw then? The clones? Go visit Prime and offer to paint him a portrait?"

"He'd probably love it," Catra mutters, still trying to reach the paper.

"Oh, what about Adora?" Glimmer exclaims, standing up on the bed fully.

Catra slumps down immediately and lets out a theatrically long sigh. "What about her, again?"

"Well, you surely remember what she looks like. Draw her."

"What is this, a requests night? Besides, I don't remember *that* well. She's got… long hair, and a tiara… A miniskirt, I suppose…"

"You're describing She-ra, not Adora."

"Yeah, potato potahto."

"Draw her and I'll give you that haircut for free."

"It won't be for free then, will it…" Catra mumbles, while placing tip of the pen back on another sheet of paper. "Let's see… here's her head… She has two eyes, I guess, and a nose… And a ginormous hair poof…"

Glimmer snorts loudly. "You've made it bigger than her entire head."

"I'm going for realism here, Sparkles. Okay, her dumb pony tail… Does she still wear that stupid red jacket?"

"Do you even need to ask?" Glimmer whines. "Can't tell you how many times I felt tempted to throw that thing into the fire and claim accident." She shifts on the bed. "Wait, I'm not being horribly insensitive right now, am I? Does it have a supersad backstory, like your mask?"

"I'm honestly envious of your life, if you thought that story was supersad," Catra says, leaning closer to the paper and squinting her eyes in concentration. "The jacket's story is more of a 'Look what I found in this pile, Catra! It makes my shoulders look so ripped!'"

"You're not the best at impressions, are you?" Glimmer tilts her head, yawning.

"*You're not the best at impressions, are you*?"

Glimmer pokes her arm repeatedly.

"Do you want me to finish that drawing or not?" Catra asks. She promptly adds finishing touches, adding a large speech bubble and writing "FOR THE HONOR OF GAYSKULL" inside of it, before handing the finished piece to the queen. "Here. My masterpiece."

"Woah…" She takes the paper in her hands with reverence. "This is honestly so much better than the royal portrait we ordered for her."

Catra groans. "She has *a royal portrait*?"

"And she said you'd never let her live it down if you knew."

"You're telling me there is *a royal portrait* of Adora somewhere in Bright Moon, and you've been trying to lure me in there with pissing and makeovers and the power of friendship? It's like you people truly don't know me," Catra shakes her head disappointedly.

"Why is she standing like this, though? Like one of her legs is higher up?" Glimmer points at the drawing.

"She's standing on something. It's a victory pose, I don't know."

"What is she standing on?"

"You can draw me under her heel," Catra hands her the pen.

"Maybe later," Glimmer puts the drawing down carefully and stifles another yawn, laying down on her back.

Catra gets up and sits on the bed next to her. "Okay, you've gotta stop that. You're making me wanna yawn."

Glimmer sighs. "Can't help that I'm sleep deprived, you know."

"Why would you be? I thought all you do when I'm not here is sleep."

"I… can't, exactly." Glimmer's tone changes and Catra can see her biting her lip. She hesitates for just a second – there is a small voice at the back of her head that reminds her this is a princess she's sitting with, after all, one that stole Adora from her at that. But then again, does she still care about that? Does she still care about *anything*?

“Hey,” she clears her throat. “You can tell me.”

Glimmer’s breath catches in surprise. “Tell you what?”

“Whatever the hell it is that doesn’t let you sleep.” Catra pauses, but then goes on before letting the silence become too awkward. “Look, I know our… arrangement usually doesn’t involve deep heart-to-hearts, unless we’re too drunk to remember about it afterwards, but… I suppose the whole point of this is to make ourselves feel a bit better, so… You can tell me. If you think that would help.”

She forces a laugh, feeling a treacherous warmth creeping up her cheeks. She hasn’t felt so awkward since trying to flirt with Adora in the Horde’s locker room, only for her to remain completely oblivious to the attempts. If Glimmer points out her blush right now, she may need to actually jump off the ship and let herself get sucked into the void.

But Glimmer either doesn’t notice, or decides to mercifully ignore it. “It’s really not anything new,” she says, shrugging. “Just… worried about things. Bow and Adora, mostly. But also how all of this is going to end.” She gestures broadly around herself.

“All of this?”

“Well… you know. This. Us, being on this ship.”

Ah. There it is.

Catra was genuinely wondering if the subject of what’s going to happen to them was ever bound to come up between them. They both did a pretty good job of keeping things down to oblique references and jokes that relieved the tension, but ultimately that was the thing keeping them both preoccupied whenever they were apart.

“I mean, it’s been weeks already,” Glimmer carries on. “Right? I’m not even sure how much time has passed. But you know, we’re here and we don’t know anything and can’t do anything, and

sometimes it's nice because we get to do dumb shit like this-" she waves her hands between the two of them. "-but then I just know there are things happening outside, without us. And this suspension we're in is going to end and we'll have to do something next… well, either that or Prime will just kill us. I don't know if I'm making any sense now."

She trails off, releasing the air from her chest in a long and weary sigh.

That small part of Catra, one that used to be so much louder up until recently, takes great offense in how often Glimmer uses the words "we" or "us". The bigger part of her is really tired of the former, though, and tells it to shut the fuck up.

"Yeah, I… guess you do," she says, slanting a look at Glimmer. "I try not to think about it too much, because, like you said, can't do a lot about it."

"I know, I know," Glimmer shakes her head. "That's why I didn't say anything. I know that you can't help that either, and I'm just upsetting you."

"Since when exactly do you care about upsetting me, Sparkles? Yesterday you insisted on blowing in my ear hard enough to give me pneumonia just because you said it was twitching cutely."

"Oh, because it was!" There is a small smile in Glimmer's voice and for some reason it makes Catra feel successful. "But you know what I mean. Like, genuinely upsetting you."

Catra knows. What she does not know is what to do with a realization of how much their relationship has changed. How did this even happen? And how come she couldn't have that with Scorpia, or Entrapta, or even Double Trouble?

"Would it help if you got some actual sleep?" she asks.

"I think so. Why?"

"I can try doing something that I think might help," she already regrets saying that and really wishes she had some alcohol on her right now.

"Like what?" Glimmer gives her an incredulous look.

"It's a… trick," Catra says, feeling herself blushing again. "I know it sounds dumb, but it used to work on Adora pretty much every time, so maybe it would help you, too."

"It used to work on *Adora*? That sounds suspicious," Glimmer chuckles. "That girl's wound up so tight she can double as a clock, there's no power that can make her relax. What did you do, punch the back of her neck? Spike her milkshake?"

"No, it's… ugh," Catra stands up. "Let's just try it, okay? Just lie down and close your dumb eyes."

Glimmer laughs shortly, but complies. Catra kneels by the bed, her hand touching the back of Glimmer's.

"Just so we're clear," she mutters. "If we do get out of here and you tell anyone about this, I'm going to murder you."

"Mmm, death threats always made me so sleepy," Glimmer smiles, eyes still shut.

Catra takes a deep breath. She really hasn't done that in what feels like ages and isn't even sure why she's willing to try it now. For a weird moment, she wonders if she still can.

She decides to close her eyes too, and pictures Adora.

Not the She-ra, bullshit Adora, but *her* Adora. Round cheeks, blue eyes, dark eyebrows that are stuck in a perpetual slight frown. Stupid, naïve, lovely Adora.

She slowly lets out a breath together with a low purr. The sound escaping her throat feels so familiar and foreign simultaneously.

She feels Glimmer stirring slightly in surprise, but then settling down, as Catra continues purring.

She focuses intensely on the image of Adora in her head. Adora, looking over the Fright Zone from their roof spot, face illuminated by the red security lights. Adora, in her disgusting sweaty training suit, waving the staff around skilfully. Adora, laughing so hard at lunch, water comes out her nostrils.

Adora, lying next to her, holding her hand, looking at her like she's everything, and Catra being able to pretend, just for a moment, that maybe she is.

"Don't worry about Octavia," Adora whispers. "One day, when we're Force Captains, we'll tell her to give us all of her grey portions."

Catra snorts with laughter into her palm. She can already hear Lonnie shifting in bed and she'd rather not deal with her calling Shadow Weaver on them again.

"She's a Force Captain too, dummy. She wouldn't have to listen to us."

"Then we'll become bigger Force Captains. Force Commanders!"

"That's not a thing."

"We'll make it a thing!"

It's dark, but Catra's eyes can see Adora's face perfectly - she's smiling with that big, sweet idiot smile of hers.

"So you're saying we'll basically need to outrank Hordak?"

"We could do that. We'll make ourselves the Horde queens, and conquer Etheria. I know there's just one throne, so you can take it, I'd look like an absolute dipshit on it."

"You mean more so than now, or..?"

Adora pokes her sides and she has to stifle another laugh.

But there is also sadness clutching at her throat. Adora really means it, she wants this life, and she believes they can actually have it.

“Adora?”

“Yeah?”

“I’m just thinking…” Catra chews on her lip for a moment. “Is this really what you want?”

She can see Adora’s eyebrows going up.

“What do you mean?”

“You know, this whole Force Captain thing. Is it what you want to do in life?”

Adora takes a moment, gripping Catra’s hand tightly.

“Well, there’s not much of a choice in career here, right?” she chuckles quietly.

“I know, just… what if we’d go somewhere else?”

“Like where?”

“Like literally anywhere but here. Then we could do something else.”

“I don’t get it, Catra. Do you want to do something else?”

“Maybe,” Catra says. “I’m curious what’s out there, is all.” Except the truth is a little closer to the little pout in Adora’s lips and the way Catra can’t stop herself from imagining how they’d feel like touching hers.

“There are princesses out there, that’s for sure,” Adora smiles, but Catra can feel the tightness in her chest increasing. “Come on,

Catra. You'll be great as a Force Captain, I'm sure! And we can make the new flags out of Kyle's pants then, how amazing is that?"

She doesn't get it. She'll never get it. The best Catra can hope for is to spend her life in the Horde by her side.

She forces a smile, glad that Adora's sight is not keen enough to see the details of her face now.

"Catra?" Adora squeezes her hand again.

"Yeah?"

She grabs her arm and shakes it a little bit.

"Catra!"

"What!" Catra opens her eyes.

She sees Glimmer's concerned face, bathed in bright light, in front of her.

"You fell asleep and I can hear a clone coming," she says in an urgent whisper.

Catra blinks a few times, trying to reset her brain. Was it another mealtime already? How long have they been asleep?

Without another word, she jumps straight to her hiding spot. Glimmer manages to cover herself up with a blanket and feign sleep by the time the guard enters and Catra slips out.

She then spends a good while walking through the corridors, trying to settle down. It's hard to even pinpoint which made her more distraught – her practically tucking in the Queen of the Rebellion she's supposed to be fighting, or her thinking about Adora like that.

It’s like she hasn’t allowed herself to think about Adora with anything but anger in years and now all the feelings she’s been storing in some deep, shameful place, came spilling out. As embarrassing, even revolting as it is, Catra’s wishes Adora was here now. She would tell her… She’s not sure. Maybe everything. Maybe nothing. They’d just sit together, letting the silence stretch between them like a thread, and it would be enough.

Walking fast, past another corner, Catra nearly bumps into a clone. She recoils instantly, tail bushy, her claws extending reflexively.

The clone just looks at her with what looks like a calm amusement on his face.

“Little sister,” he says, sending a shiver down her spine. “Lord Prime requests your presence.”

Glimmer

When the clone number 497 leaves the cell carrying an empty tray the next day, and Glimmer looks around to see no sign of Catra anywhere, she's surprised but not worried. She half-expected her to flee in terror once she's realized she made herself too vulnerable for her liking. Glimmer imagines she ran off to cower somewhere in a dark corner, calculating the exact amount of time she needs to stay away from their hangouts in order to play it cool.

But when several more mealtimes pass by and Catra doesn't show, there is a tiny hint of concern lodging itself somewhere at the back of Glimmer's mind. It's still probably nothing, but now there's a possibility, a miniscule one, that perhaps it's something. It grows every time the green door flickers closed and Glimmer looks around but sees no glowing mismatched eyes underneath a nest of dark hair.

The isolation and idleness probably makes her overthink things, but by the third day, she begins toying with the idea of asking one of the clones for Catra.

As if she doesn't already have enough to worry about, Glimmer thinks angrily, lying on the bed with her feet propped high up against the wall.

The thing is, she can't quite bring herself to fully reflect on why she feels that way, exactly. It isn't a purely selfish desire to have someone to distract her in her own plight, but she doesn't think she cares much what happens to Catra either. It's not like they're friends - they both made it abundantly clear that their ceasefire was born out of absolute necessity. Glimmer wants Catra to join them, sure, but it's really mostly for strategic purposes, and Adora, to an extent.

And yet, the second Glimmer notices a smudge of movement by the green door out of the corner of her eye, she feels a wave of

relief washing over her. She wills herself not to look in that direction until she's well sure that the guard is gone, then turns around to face Catra, her cheeks a little puffed.

"Nice of you to show," she says, folding her arms angrily, just about ready to deliver some strong arguments until Catra apologizes for effectively ghosting her.

But then, with a start, she notices Catra's face.

It looks *greyer*, drained it of all the usual colour. Her eyes are bloodshot, with dark circles around them, her mouth is a thin, tense line. Her hair looks matted and disheveled, as if she's spent the entire time pulling on and twisting it.

"What the hell happened to you?" Glimmer walks up to her, the concern making itself known in her voice. "You look like shit."

Catra opens her mouth, but then closes it, scrubbing a hand across her face.

"I don't… really want to talk about it," she says, shaking her head lightly.

"But-"

"Look, it's nothing, okay?" Catra walks around her to sink heavily into the bed. "I just really don't feel like talking about it now."

This withdrawn, secretive side of her really starts to get on Glimmer's nerves. It's truly hard to believe that there used to be a time when Glimmer thought Catra was so obvious, just an immature, spiteful brat with nothing else of interest to be found underneath the surface. She sometimes misses the simplicity of those times. Now the more they talk, the more incomprehensible she is.

"It's not fair, you know," Glimmer gives her a hard glare.

"What's not?"

“I mean… This would have been mildly annoying under regular circumstances, but the way things are now? You get to walk out and disappear for days without an explanation and I just have to put up with it, no questions asked?” she huffs.

“No, you don’t have to. You can tell me to leave,” Catra offers.

“Yeah, see, that’s basically blackmail, isn’t it? *‘You put up with my bullshit or I go and you can rot in here’*, that’s hardly fair, huh?”

“Geez,” Catra exhales heavily. “How come you care so much about fairness all of a sudden?”

“I always care about fairness.”

“*Really*,” Catra looks up at her with exhausted eyes. “You, the Queen of Bright Moon, caring about fairness?”

“Why is this in any way strange to you?”

“Forget it,” she grumbles.

Glimmer throws her hands up in exasperation. “Oh great, here we go again!”

“Which part of ‘I don’t want to talk about it’ did you think was up for debate? I don’t want to argue right now, how come it’s so hard to understand?” Catra says, crossing arms and holding herself protectively.

“It is, if you’re ghosting me for days and then imply that you think I’m a hypocrite!”

“Ugh!” She hides her face behind the crook of her elbow. “You’re just like *her*, you know. You’re just keep pushing and pushing!”

“We wouldn’t have to push, if you just told us what how you’re feeling like a normal person instead of bottling it up!”

"Geez, will you ever stop it! Always bugging me about my *feelings* and *Adora*," she claps a hand over her face and slowly wipes it across. "How about this, Glimmer – I'm *not ready* to talk about this now. Can we please talk about something else."

That effectively shuts Glimmer's face up. She sinks down into a chair and leans forward.

"Okay," she concedes. "But are you sure you're alright? Like, medically speaking. Because it sounded like you just got possessed by someone who's a whole lot more emotionally mature than you."

"Screw you," a corner of Catra's mouth quirks up and, for a moment, even her eyes look a bit more alive. "I'm just full of surprises. You still know nothing about me."

Yup, definitely missing the simpler times.

"Oh good, there's the Horde Scum I know," Glimmer smiles back. She finally takes a moment to scan Catra's hands. "No booze today? No snacks?"

"Let's say I've had some difficulties. Plus, I figured you must have a sizeable stash of your own at this point," she lifts up the edge of the mattress to rummage through Glimmer's collection. "Let's see, want some peanuts?"

She throws a packet in Glimmer's direction and opens one for herself. They spend a good minute quietly chewing their snacks. It's strangely soothing, really – Glimmer is reminded of the peaceful afternoons she spent with Bow and Adora in her room. They didn't even talk, each of them doing their own thing, just sharing snacks and space.

"So," Catra is the one to break the silence eventually. "I was thinking how you're always pushing me to talk about my life, but barely mention yours, really."

“I talk about it all the time?” Glimmer points the packet at Catra, feigning terror. “I knew there was something wrong. You have amnesia, don’t you?”

Catra makes a strangled noise. “You talk about Bow and Adora a lot, not your life.”

“Lately they’ve been occupying a big chunk of my life, you know.”

“That’s not what I mean!” Catra waves her hand dismissively. “I meant like, your childhood. What’s it like growing up a princess in a castle?”

Glimmer’s breath catches in surprise. “Are you… really interested in that sort of stuff?”

“Yeah, sure. Well, the Horde’s been teaching us some outright insane things about you people, but I’m pretty sure Adora was the only one innocent enough to buy it.”

“Bless her soul,” Glimmer sighs theatrically.

“You wanna tell me what it’s really like then?” Catra asks, before tossing a peanut into the air to catch it with her mouth.

Glimmer gawks at her for a bit and clears her throat. “I mean… I could tell you, it’s just… a bit weird, isn’t it?”

“How so?”

“Well…” Glimmer gestures as if to illustrate her thought process. “It always feels a bit weird talking about it without sounding like I’m a spoiled little shit.”

She feels herself blushing, when Catra bursts out laughing. “Oh, Sparkles. I always think you’re a spoiled little shit, so you might as well tell me.”

Glimmer pouts, her face getting warmer. “I hate you with a passion beyond reason.”

Catra blows a kiss in her direction.

Then Glimmer starts talking. She tells Catra about Bright Moon's castle, rooms with high-ceilings, shiny immaculate marble floors and ornately carved windows overlooking vibrant gardens. How she used to flicker unwillingly before learning to teleport and ended up on the roof once when she was four. Her mother was absolutely mortified as she flew up to retrieve her, but Glimmer mostly remembers a breath taking sight and how she first fully understood there was a world outside their castle and has been dying to see all of it ever since. She talks about her first meeting with Bow and how things were when there was just the two of them. His first arrows and crooked shots. Her trying to show off and teleporting until she collapsed. The ridiculous dance routines they practiced before balls in matching outfits.

She tells Catra how she was five when she realized they were at war with the Horde and wanted nothing more than to fight them. How her mother had to put a shielding spell over the briefing room to stop her from teleporting into it. How she couldn't sleep the entire night once mother finally let her join the council and fell asleep in the middle of her first meeting as a result.

Catra listens intently, going through her second pack of peanuts. To her credit, she limits her eye rolls to a minimum.

"Sounds like you still did better than I," she says, licking the salt off her fingers. "I skipped my Force Captain briefing. Scorpia had to get me up to speed on every little dumb thing later."

"I'd rather not think how much of a pain in the ass you'd have been, had you not skipped it," Glimmer stretches her lips in a smile and throws a peanut that bounces of Catra's mask.

"Oh trust me, once I finally learn all the supply shipment routes, it's all over for you."

Glimmer releases a long-suffering sigh.

"There's so much bullshit you need to manage when you're in charge. Nobody ever tells you that."

"Right? I once spent ten hours straight over spreadsheets on machine productivity, by the end I started wishing Adora would show up to kick my ass just so I could feel alive again!"

"And those endless meetings! I used to think it was just the Princess Council, but then there were so many advisors, and diplomats, and merchants I've had to talk to… I thought my face would get stuck in that permanent polite smile I had to put on," she groans, massaging her cheeks. "And all those people talking to me like we've been besties for years when I couldn't remember their names half the time."

"Oh, I've never had that problem," Catra grins. "The best my people can do is to temporarily stop talking shit about me when I walk into the room."

Glimmer laughs heartily. "I thought it was just our side hating your guts?"

"Sparkles, when I said no one wants me back on Etheria, I meant it," Catra chews on the last of her peanuts before crumpling the packet and tossing it aside. "I guess in the end, neither one of us was all that great at our jobs."

"Eh. We did get *some* things done."

"Yes, most notably, this thing," Catra gestures at the ship all around them. "Couldn't have done this without you, my dear Sparkles."

Glimmer bites her lip, feeling instantly deflated. Despite her exhaustion, Catra is quick to notice.

"Hey, don't feel too bad," she says. "At least you meant well. All I wanted at the time was to fuck shit up."

“I wonder if I did,” Glimmer sighs. “Or if this was really just a way for me to prove myself to everyone. Show them that I’m just as capable as my mother.”

A heavy silence falls between them.

If there is one thing that no amount of talking and playing cards can erase, it’s Angella’s demise and the role Catra had in it. There were times when Glimmer wanted to murder Catra on sight for all of it, but now she struggles to think of what to say to her. There seems to be an unspoken agreement between them to leave the subject well enough alone, though.

They need each other to survive now, and there’s no way they can still stand to be around each other if they start talking about this.

“I wonder,” Catra speaks eventually. “Why haven’t you said anything about your dad?”

Glimmer feels her stomach dropping just a little. “What.”

“I mean, through all of your monologue today, you haven’t mentioned him once,” Catra tilts her head at her. “In fact, I can’t recall you mentioning him more than once since we’re on Prime’s ship.”

“I-…” Glimmer stutters. “I’m sure I’ve mentioned him, you just don’t remember.”

“And I’m sure you haven’t. Talk about repressed feelings, huh?”

“Now you’re just projecting,” Glimmer snarks.

Catra slants a look at her. “Am I, though? Let’s see, you’ve spent most of your life believing him dead, only to find out he’s back, just as you’ve gone on a long space vacation aboard this ship,” Catra waves a hand in a dismissive gesture. “I’m not exactly an expert, but I suspect this is something that could possibly evoke emotions in some people. And yet, you’ve never mentioned it.”

Glimmer's eyes dart to the side. "Maybe you just never asked about him before."

"I never asked you to tell me about that one dream about Bow you've had in excruciating detail, and that didn't stop you. I can tell you've been avoiding this topic."

Glimmer hugs one knee to her chest. "It's just… I don't really remember him that well. My entire life everyone's been telling me things about him. And I don't just mean, mom sitting me down on her lap and telling me a hour-long story about how they met, or that time he saved a peace treaty by creating a magic light show at a banquet. I mean, mom and aunt would mention him constantly, so much I doubt they were even aware of it."

She smiles to herself, looking down at her fingernails. "When I was being stubborn, mom would mention how much I take after my father, or when I made a face, aunt Casta would call me 'tiny Micah'. They were those little bits of information and I used to automatically memorize and categorize all of them into this big pile of Dad Files in my brain. Like, I know my dad likes lemon cupcakes, sneezes loudly and falls asleep if you leave him sitting in the garden for more than a minute, but I've never *seen* him do any of that, you know?"

Catra nods, looking at her steadily.

"So at some point I've used all those files and created this imaginary dad in my head," Glimmer carries on. "It was comforting, somehow. He was perfect, and I felt like I knew him that way. But… he was dead. I was so sure that this make-believe dad was the only one I was ever gonna have, and…" She trails off, biting down on her lip.

But Catra's ears perk up in understanding. "…and now you're worried that he's not going to be what you imagined."

Glimmer gives her a crooked shrug. "I know he's not. I'm not naïve enough to believe he would be."

“Then what’s the problem?”

“I guess… I’m worried that I won’t be able to let go of the imaginary dad. I’ll meet the real one and won’t be able to have a relationship with him because of it,” she exhales slowly. “Or worse yet, what if I’m not what he’s pictured me to be? What if we finally meet and we’re both just… disappointed?”

She rubs her forehead, looking down on the floor tiles. Few seconds pass before she can hear Catra’s weight shifting on the bed.

“I’m not exactly an expert on parents,” she says quietly. “But I think you’ll be fine.”

Glimmer’s breath catches. “Sorry.”

“What the hell for?”

“See, I didn’t want to go into the subject, because it feels so idiotic complaining about this to you of all people.”

Catra tenses up slightly and he tail swings a little to the side. “Why?”

“Because you have it so much worse than I do in that department. You must be thinking I should be happy and I’m creating problems for myself for no reason.”

“If I were thinking that, I would say it. Although honestly, I’m not sure what to say either. What would your friends say if you told them all this?”

Though it all, Glimmer smiles to herself at the picture. “Adora would probably stay up all night to make a huge spreadsheet of all the possible scenarios to help me plan our meeting in advance, then suggest to wear an earpiece so she could offer me tips from some book on father-daughter relationships. And Bow would comfort and hug me and then be there for when I first see him as my emotional support squeeze.”

“Well, dammit. I was just about to offer that.”

“Too bad. And you’re way too lanky to be my squeeze, anyway.”

A beat of silence, again.

“I became disillusioned with Shadow Weaver long before Adora left,” Catra says finally. “I didn’t have any hopes for her to suddenly wake up and be a real mother to me. But when she was about to killed, I… could have done just about anything to save her.”

Glimmer’s eyes snap back up on her. “You think you loved her? Despite everything?”

“I’m not sure I did. I think I just got scared,” Catra says, voice just an octave too high. “She’s a spiteful, evil woman, and our relationship was crap, not the regular crap either, more like a post-competitive-burrito-eating crap. But if she died, then… I’d have to fully and finally accept that now there is no chance it will ever be any less crap.”

“That sounds… depressing.”

“My point is, you’re getting your dad back. You might have a great relationship with him, or a shitty one, or even boring, averagely amicable one. But you will have something.”

She gives Glimmer the most earnest look she’s seen from her yet.

“That… oddly enough makes me feel better. Although I wonder if it was in part you throwing me off again by telling me sad things about your life.”

“Always at your service, Queen Muffin-face.”

Glimmer nods and lets the rhythm of their banter die out. Since Catra is busy staring at her feet, she takes the opportunity to study her face and the shadows of expressions passing over it.

“When do you think you’ll be ready?” she asks, reaching over to poke Catra’s knee.

“Hm?” Catra raises her head.

“To tell me what happened.”

For a moment, there’s no sound but a steady hum of the ship.

“I don’t know,” she admits. “And look, I know this must be annoying. All I can tell you is that… I don’t think this is going to last much longer.”

She doesn’t need to specify what she means.

“What makes you say that?” Glimmer asks, feeling her throat drying up.

“Honestly, it’s just a feeling I have,” Catra glances up at her, hesitant. “Though, if it’s any consolation… Well, I think I may have found a way for us to escape.”

Glimmer’s mouth drops open at that.

“You *what*?” she stands up abruptly enough to upset the empty glasses on the little table. “And you didn’t think to mention this earlier?!”

“Emphasis on ‘*I think*’!” Catra raises her palms defensively. “It’s nothing certain, so, don’t get your hopes up.”

“It’s too late for that! My hopes are way up already!” Glimmer jumps up to the bed to sit herself by Catra’s side.

“Well, put them back down then!”

“I can’t! You have to tell me more!”

“It’s… too dangerous,” Catra moves away an inch. “Just, act normally, okay? If something happens, I’ll let you know.”

Glimmer stands back up again and loudly cracks her knuckles.

“What are you doing?” Catra arches an eyebrow at her.

“Acting normally. Getting ready to throw hands.”

Catra snorts with laughter and rolls herself onto bed. “Have I mentioned that you’re an absolute nightmare lately?”

Glimmer sinks into bed, gently pushing a strand of hair behind her ear.

“You know I was… worried, when you were gone,” she says. Catra gives her a confused look.

“Well, I’m fine, as you can see.”

“Except I can’t, really? You show up here looking like this and expect me to just be cool about it?”

Catra rubs her eyes forcefully, giving them an even more bloodshot look. “I’m really okay though. Just tired, I’m sure you know the feeling.”

Glimmer leans over her. “Do you want me to try something to help you relax?”

“I don’t think you… doing what I did last time would be helpful to me,” Catra clears her throat, cheeks gaining a slight shade of pink at the memory. “Plus, I shouldn’t be sleeping here.”

“Oh, I’m not going to purr at you, don’t worry. I just… Can I take your mask off for a bit?”

Catra’s eyes snap open at that.

“Why?” her hands grab the mask’s edged instantly, as if she expects Glimmer to snatch it off her face any second.

“Always wanted to try it on and see if I feel more badass that way,” she deadpans. “I just want to touch your hair, dummy. You’ll

get it back.” Seeing Catra’s hesitant expression, she adds: “And I’ll try my hardest not to make fun of your hairline.”

Catra rolls her eyes, but a corner of her lip quirks up. She carefully pulls her mask up and places it by the pillow, then closes her eyes.

Glimmer touches the scrunched up spot between her eyebrows. “Are you even aware how much you’re constantly frowning?”

“Shut up,” Catra mumbles, keeping her eyes closed.

Glimmer chuckles, then slowly runs her fingers through the thickness of Catra’s mane.

This was something her mom used to do to soothe her when she was little. It didn’t always manage to make her drowsy, but she always liked it nonetheless, especially when she paired it up with a story told in a quiet voice. It was such an intense feeling of being loved and protected. She really misses it.

“I tried this on Adora a couple of times, but she’s completely immune,” she whispers. Catra smiles and hums in agreement, her face finally relaxing, as Glimmer continues stroking her hair. “It might be that your purring is the only thing that can actually put her to sleep.”

“Are you saying she hasn’t slept in three years?” Catra asks back in a groggy voice.

“Barely. It’s a shame you haven’t joined us along with her, would be interesting to know Adora who isn’t perpetually sleep deprived.”

“Sometimes I wonder,” Catra yawns. “What would it be like. If I had gone with her back then.”

“I would have roped you in to do all my paperwork for me by now, that’s for sure,” Glimmer says. “That and, we probably wouldn’t be in all this mess right now.”

“Mmm,” Catra agrees.

Glimmer isn’t sure how much time they spend like this, exactly. At some point Catra dozes off, while she continues gently untangling her hair, lost in thought.

Okay, so, maybe it’s stupid of her. Maybe it’s an insult to her mother’s memory. But Glimmer has no choice but to admit to herself that she’s grown to care about this depressed, snarky, triangle-eared, complex ball of weird emotions Horde Scum.

And now she finds herself wondering if there’s any chance for both of them to get back home safely.

Catra

Who would have thought that breaking Sparkles out of prison and shipping her off to Adora was the *easy* part of the plan.

Catra sits on the floor of Glimmer's former cell, back against the bedframe, staring into space and mindlessly rubbing her cheek. She got roughed up pretty good by the clones, although it's still not that impressive considering she went up alone against the entire horde of them. If there is anything to be proud of, it's probably just how much unexpected inconvenience she was able to cause for Prime.

She drags her claws against the bedframe, destroying another piece of his furniture for good measure. It vividly reminds her of being back in the Fright Zone, and how she used to scratch out rude words and drawings over the walls just to piss off Shadow Weaver and whichever poor Force Captain happened to be looking after the kids that day. There was something profoundly satisfying about being a huge pain in the ass for those who underestimated her.

Her cheek still really stings, though.

Worse yet, there is a very strange turmoil of emotions inside her. For one, she's relieved – she did it, Glimmer is safe, and that means Adora is safe, too. Sparkles will go back to Etheria, rule it with her just yet glittery hand, meet her dad, stuff her face with cake, hook up with the arrow enthusiast, possibly have the lamest babies in Etheria. Good for her. Adora will save the world again and… continue saving the world, probably, or do whatever it is she wants. Maybe she'll find it in her to actually forgive Catra for all this bullshit and think of her with some fond nostalgia once every decade or so. It's really the best she can hope for.

But there's also a small dose of hurt mixed in. The little part of her despairing that Adora isn't coming back for her.

It’s idiotic. She knows it is – if Adora actually ignores her warning and shows up here, she’ll most certainly get herself killed and then all this effort would be for nothing. Even if Adora would want to risk her own life for a piece of shit like Catra, there is no way she’d risk sacrificing She-ra, not when Etheria needs her so much. And still, this dumb, annoying, childish, self-pitying particle of Catra would be overjoyed to see Adora kicking down the Velvet Glove’s door.

She won’t, though. And it makes Catra want to wail.

The second she got dragged in front of Prime, she promised herself she wouldn’t cry. Of course she is scared shitless, but there is nothing she can do that would improve her situation in any way. Might as well suck it up and die with some dignity.

Ugh. Her and dignity? Double Trouble would have such a laugh at that.

Suddenly Catra wishes she had some space alcohol to talk to about all this. She gets up, feeling the ache in a few more beat up body parts, and lifts the edge of the mattress, only to find Glimmer’s stash thoroughly cleaned.

Well, shit.

So, turns out Prime’s vague threats weren’t completely clueless, he somehow knew Catra’s been sneaking in here all along. Why didn’t he say anything sooner? If he didn’t care about her spending time with the enemy, why take so long to try having Catra interrogate Glimmer? He is still so hard to decipher and Catra hates that about him. She thinks of Hordak and Shadow Weaver with an almost-fondness, just because they were so hilariously easy to read through.

She leans back, sinking further into the floor, resting her unbruised cheek against the linen. It still smells like Sparkles, a scent that always reminds her of meringue in a cotton candy ball with a pound of sugar sprinkles on top. Funny how someone who

seems so sickly sweet can actually be so interesting. For a short moment, Glimmer was truly a perfect friend material for Catra, all things considered – someone who would never, ever leave her, because they're physically incapable of doing so. There was a strange sense of comfort that came along with it, knowing that she would still be here the next day, and then the next one too. Honestly, how come Catra didn't think of locking all of her friends up sooner?

She makes a mental note to tell Glimmer that sad self-deprecating joke later, only to remember she'll never see her again.

One of the last times Catra visited her, Sparkles talked again about how things would look like if Catra joins the Rebellion. How they'd all become friends, and have their inside jokes, and matching outfits, how Glimmer would make dumplings for them, how Bow would make a new Catra figurine for their lame nerdy board game, how they'd all make fun of Adora's turtleneck, and play charades at their sleepovers. Not only was her fantasy annoyingly idyllic, it was all just so unthinkable, it put Adora's old adorably naïve projections of their future as Horde Queens to shame.

And yet, Catra finds herself unable to stop thinking about it. She imagines the room Glimmer promised to give her, with a high-suspended soft bed, and their trip to Mystacor, where aunt Casta, whoever the hell that is, gives her a personalized sweater. Most of all, she pictures herself with Adora again. On the same side, and safe, because nothing can happen to them as long as they are together…

The sound of footsteps approaching causes her to lift her head up in a start. Habit nearly makes her to jump straight to her old hiding spot.

Four clones approach the green door in a perfectly choreographed formation, with one of them stepping forward and opening it. Catra briefly thinks that it's excessive to send so many of them to escort one prisoner, but this was probably the closest Prime would get to complimenting her.

“Little sister?” One of them gestures at her, and Catra stands up, biting her lip to stifle a grunt. They tie up her hands again and lead her outside through the corridor. She feels an odd sense of loss, giving one last look at Glimmer’s old cell.

Once she stands in front of Horde Prime, there’s already thousands of clones surrounding her and Catra wonders if any of them is Hordak. She probably wouldn’t recognize him anymore. Prime’s there, standing up from his dumb throne to slowly walk towards her, looking down at her with all of his eyes.

“Little sister,” the way he says this makes Catra nauseous already.

She swallows with difficulty, still determined to give him nothing. “Prime,” she says hoarsely.

He gets uncomfortably close, staring her up and down, and keeping eye contact starts being difficult. “You think I am underestimating you,” he says.

Catra doesn’t know what to answer to this, or if he even expects her to.

“You are wrong, little sister. I can see your potential and it is a great one,” he reaches out to her face and it takes all of her willpower to avoid wincing. “But you can never reach it, not when you are letting so much hold you back.”

He takes a strand of her hair between his white corpse-like fingers and plays with it. “So much unnecessary weight that you are carrying. Worry not, little sister, I will take it all off your shoulders. I will set you free. And by my side, you will reach true greatness and you will finally be at peace.”

As he steps aside to reveal the pool of green behind him, Catra feels her throat tightening up, eyesight getting blurred and nose stuffy.

She was never any good at keeping promises.

Glimmer

Mara's ship is decisively too quiet for Glimmer's liking.

It's all shiny metal and smoothly running machinery in a way that eerily reminds her of Prime's ship, all that's missing is a puke-worthy amount of lime green lights and the ever-present clones hounding every corner. And Catra, she supposes.

It started of well, honestly. Glimmer's reunion with Bow and Adora went pretty much exactly the way she's always imagined it would – there were dramatic hugs and tears and waves of relief almost palpable in the air around them, it was like for an instant, all three of them let themselves feel the unbridled joy at the Best Friend Squad being together again at last. But that moment passed away far too quickly, with so many other things creeping back into view and obscuring their elation.

There was Bow, still being clearly very cross with her. When she walks into the ship's kitchen, he is sitting by the counter, his regular outfit abandoned for soft pyjamas, gaze focused on his tablet. He pointedly ignores her standing at the doorstep, but she can tell he's noticed her by the way his brows furrow.

"Um, hi," Glimmer says lamely. She absolutely hates this awkwardness she feels now around someone she's always been the most comfortable with.

Bow barely lifts his eyes. "Hi," he grumbles back, before returning to his tablet. Glimmer is pretty sure there is absolutely nothing on the screen.

"I'm just here to get some tea," she says, pointing at the electric kettle, trying her best to sound reasonably carefree. That was a lie, she was actually just wandering around the ship pointlessly, trying to walk off her restlessness, but if she were to leave the kitchen without getting anything from it now, the uneasiness would probably cause her to spontaneously combust on the spot.

She promptly realizes her mistake, once the kettle switch is on and the water begins fizzling lazily. She's never felt so panicked about water taking a few minutes to boil.

"Oh, that one smells good. Almost like the one we had back in Plumeria," she says, theatrically sniffing at one of the tea cans.

"Mhm," Bow replies, not lifting his gaze this time. His mouth is now very tense at the corners.

Glimmer is reminded of when they were kids, maybe seven and nine years old and Bow stayed mad at her for several hours after she called his arrows stupid in a fit of frustration, because her teleporting wasn't going well. It was a rare and memorable occurrence for Bow to be the one who got offended – nine times out of ten, Glimmer was the pouting party. She recalls how back then she pretty much just annoyed him all day with progressively sillier jokes, until he finally gave in and laughed with her.

And now she's standing here, making embarrassing small talk with the boy she loves more than anyone as if he's a foreign land diplomat with a stiff upper lip for her to charm at a gala. Things really used to be so much simpler.

"I see Entrapta's back in her element again. Haven't seen her leave the engine room since I got here," Glimmer chuckles, slanting a look at the kettle, wishing more than ever she'd just gone for a bag of chocolate snacks instead.

"Yeah, well," Bow clears his throat. "It's because we got her back from the island." He takes a pause. "…Along with your dad."

Glimmer tenses up even further, but works herself up into another painful chuckle. "Well, nobody knew he was there, right?"

"If you did, would you have gone to get him instead of listening to Shadow Weaver of all people?" Bow looks up, finally done with pretending to be engaged in whatever was happening on his tablet.

"I said I was sorry, Bow," she says, gripping on the edge of the counter.

"Yeah, sometimes 'sorry' just doesn't cut it, you know?"

"What *else* do you want me to do then?"

"I don't know!" he throws his hands up in exasperation. He sounds frighteningly genuine. "I just… don't know."

He gets up, angrily swiping his tablet along and leaves the kitchen in rush, just as the kettle finally switches itself of. Glimmer takes a shaky breath, before slowly pouring in her tea.

She promptly leaves the kitchen, scalding cup of tea in her hands, determined to walk around the ship until she finds a hatch she could hurl herself into space from. Come to think of it, she never apologized for calling his arrows stupid.

The thing is, Glimmer knows Bow well enough to realize that this isn't even about the whole 'nearly blowing up the planet' issue. It's about her choosing her dumb pride over trusting him, in a way that was unprecedented over the course of their life-long friendship. It's not like she can even blame him for being this angry, but every time she sees him looking at her and wincing like he's just accidentally touched a piece of food in the sink, her heart breaks just a little.

How does she even begin to fix something like that? Does Bow even *want it* to be fixed?

Is this how Catra felt about Adora? Like she's gone too far to be forgiven anyway, so might as well fuck things up even more?

Glimmer can't quite believe how much she wishes Catra were here now. She'd probably say something overflowing with sarcasm to mock their lovely-dovey friendship, call her a spoiled brat Muffin-Face Princess, and then awkwardly pat her shoulder. And for some reason, it would make Glimmer feel a whole lot better.

But given that Catra is very likely either already dead or being horribly tortured right now, wanting her here for herself makes Glimmer feel like the most selfish person in the galaxy. She really *is* a spoiled brat, huh?

Just then, her train of thoughts gets interrupted and she nearly spills the teacup's contents all over herself, as she hears what is most definitely Catra's voice coming from the steering room.

She rushes forward, heart somewhere up in her throat, then slams the big button to open up the door.

"CAT-"

She stops short. The room is empty, save for Adora, slumped over the controls counter, her face illuminated in darkness by the blinking control lights and a slowly spinning globe-shaped hologram. She taps at the buttons idly, staring off into space. Then there's a static sound and Glimmer can finally make out the words she's heard:

"You need to get to these coordinates *now*. Don't come here, no matter what!"

There's some muffled grunting and sounds of a fight. Then Catra again: "Horde Prime is ready for you!"

"Catra, I don't understand! What is…" Adora's voice says from the speakers.

"Just *listen*!" More grunts and hitting. Something that sounds like Glimmer screeching in the far-off background. "Adora, I'm *sorry*! For everything!"

There's a chaos of sounds, culminating in what was probably someone straight up slamming the microphone with their body, Adora's: "No, no, no, no, no, no, no, no, no! Catra! Come back!", then nothing but static.

Adora stares at the console for several seconds, before tapping at it again.

The static stops, and Catra's voice booms over the room again: "Adora? Don't sound so happy to hear me…"

Glimmer clears her throat loudly. Adora jumps a foot over the floor, then slams her hands on the console frantically, until the recording goes quiet.

"Sorry!" Glimmer says, walking up to her. "I didn't mean to scare you like that, I just…" she looks down at her own hands. "…I brought you some tea."

Adora stares her up and down, leaning back over the controls as if she was trying to cover the entire counter up with her body. "Oh! Um, thank you so much, Glimmer!"

She takes the teacup with nervous hands and starts sipping on a still too hot tea. Glimmer bites her lip and perches on the armrest of the captain's seat. They sit opposite each other in silence for a moment, Adora still giving herself mouth burns with tea.

"So… How are you?" Glimmer asks, searching Adora's face.

"Me? Oh, I'm… I'm fine, thanks!" Adora says, voice progressively rising in pitch. She promptly takes another sip, slurping loudly. "How are you?"

"I'm… just relieved to be out of Prime's range," she says, shrugging.

Another beat of silence passes between them. Glimmer starts wondering when would be an appropriate time to politely leave and possibly lock herself up in a closet somewhere to avoid weird encounters with her friends for the rest of her life, when Adora finally says: "So… Why do you think Catra sent you to us?"

Glimmer, who was already halfway standing, sits back down again. "I told you, she said she did it for you. She wanted to

protect you from going there."

"Yeah, but why *now*?" Adora spins the teacup in her hands. "Like… I don't get it. We've been fighting for the past three years. Not only she hasn't tried to protect me, she's tried to kill me herself, and came darn close a bunch of times." She places the empty cup on the counter so forcefully, it nearly breaks in half. "… and now that we haven't talked to each other in like, a year, she decides she wants to *save* me? *Why*?"

Glimmer takes a deep breath. "I really don't know," she says, folding her arms. "I… We used to hang out on the ship, but she really didn't say anything that would decisively explain that…"

Adora rises so quickly, she finally manages to knock the teacup off. It shatters on the floor, startling both of them.

"*Shit*!" She kneels down to gather the broken pieces. "Sorry, I'm just gonna… Uh…"

Glimmer gets down beside her. "Adora, leave it, you're just gonna cut yourself…"

"No, wait, I gotta…"

"Leave it," Glimmer says emphatically, before grabbing Adora's hands to stop her from digging through broken porcelain. "We'll get a broom in a second."

Adora lets out a long sigh.

"…you said you were *hanging out*?" she asks, sitting back on the floor.

"Well, yeah," Glimmer bites her lip. "I guess with everything that's been happening, I just… didn't get into details. But she used to sneak into my cell and visit me. Pretty often."

Adora looks at her with saucer-like eyes. "Why?"

"I'm… honestly not sure. I guess she was lonely and… Maybe Prime cast her aside a bit… I think there were some things going on back on Etheria that she didn't tell me about…" Glimmer lifts up both of her hands. "All I know is that I was feeling desperate and… maybe she was, too."

Adora pulls on her fingers, brows furrowed, trying to process what she's just heard.

"So you'd… hang out… and do what?" she asks eventually.

"She'd… bring snacks and some games, so we'd pass the time playing them, like with, uh, cards and stuff… We got drunk a few times, I was messing her hair up, she was drawing… But mostly we just… talked. About some dumb… stuff. Like sleepovers?" Glimmer isn't quite sure why talking about it to Adora makes her feel so embarrassed all of a sudden. Maybe it's the sheer contrast between all the, well, *fun* she and Catra had, and the atrociously grim atmosphere on Mara's ship. Or maybe she feels like befriending Catra was something a bit off-limits. Like dating a girl your best friend has a crush on.

Adora scans her face incredulously with tired eyes, so Glimmer decides to plow onward, by way of proof, waving her hand around: "She once told me you two had a sleepover back in the Fright Zone and you were talking late into the night, you started falling asleep… so then she leaned to your ear and said 'peepee poopoo' and you ended up laughing so hard, you threw up into Kyle's shoes."

Glimmer chuckles under her breath a little at the memory, but stops immediately, when she sees the brightness in Adora's eyes starting to look a lot like tears.

"Adora… I'm so sorry," Glimmer leans over the pieces of the broken teacup to touch Adora's knee.

"I just don't understand," Adora says in a tight voice, spine braced against the console. "I asked her to join us so many times. I

practically begged her, she said she was never going to go with me and now… Now that she might already be…"

She shakes her head and lets out a strangled sob and Glimmer's throat feels tighter at the sight. Adora's always been the toughest one of their group, the one who didn't give in or back down no matter how dire the situation was. Seeing her with head hung low, so defeated, was physically painful. She grips tighter on her knee.

Then she remembers something.

"Hey, so… I got something for you," she taps on Adora's shoulder and hands her a folded piece of paper. "I kept the drawings she made in my pocket and… Well, this one's of you."

Adora unfolds the paper so fast, she nearly cuts her fingers on it. She studies it intensely for a good minute before inhaling sharply and letting out a quick, teary laugh.

"Of course she'd make the hair poof huge…" she says with a sad smile, wiping her eyes forcefully.

"Adora, just…" Glimmer grabs her hands again. "Whatever you choose to do, I'm going to support you in it."

They don't need to specify what she means. It's quite clear that it's what Adora's been thinking about it since the second Glimmer landed on Mara's ship.

Adora spends a moment running her fingers on paper, studying the lines, as if she wanted them to spell out a secret message from Catra. Then she folds it back and places in her pocket.

"I'm… gonna go get the broom," she says hoarsely, standing up. "Thanks for the tea, Glimmer." She walks off, leaving Glimmer alone, bathed in the flickering lights of the controls.

Glimmer stands up and gazes out the front window, as they zoom through the stars. It's quiet again, save for the steady hum of the

ship’s engine, but this time it doesn’t bother her as much. In fact, for the first time since she got here, she feels genuinely hopeful.

Must be the determined look that she noticed appearing on Adora’s face.

Catra

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Back in the Fright Zone, just by their spot on the roof, there was an old, dilapidated storage room. Whoever designed it must have been either extraordinarily bad at their job or downright spiteful, because they placed a bunch of thick pipes right outside the entrance which made it nearly impossible to enter.

Unless, of course, you were the size of a seven-year-old girl.

Catra and Adora have claimed it as their hiding spot. There it was, their tiny little club house, full of oddly-shaped stones, toys made out of broken bot parts, stacks of library books past their return date and all the other crap that would otherwise get confiscated. It had a single bare overhead lightbulb, which did a good enough job illuminating the walls that served as canvases to the masterpieces etched on them. A bunch of self-portraits. An inspired caricature of Hordak. A mesmerizing likeness of an evil princess. More self-portraits, but as the brave Horde Captains. An ominous sign that read 'SHADOW WEEVER STINKS'. And another, that served as a reminded to anyone who'd dare to trespass: 'CATRA & ADORA WERE HERE'.

Perhaps Adora wasn't quite as attached to it, but for Catra, the place was sacred. She remembers the day they run up to the roof only to find out the room finally got demolished to make space for another weaponry.

She didn't even care about getting in trouble for all the contraband she'd stored in there and all the insulting vandalism she'd created. All she remembers is the sinking, desperate feeling of losing the walls she could hide behind.

She recognizes the same sensation as she lies still on her back, gaze fixed on the high ceiling of Mara's ship. Being unexpectedly,

painfully exposed.

A knock on the door interrupts her musings and for a second, Catra considers pretending to be fast asleep.

It's been a few days since Adora rescued her from Prime's clutches and most of them went by in a blur of nightmares, the white face watching her and the air being knocked out of her lungs, as she sinks in a pool of green. Her brain being rummaged through, like it's an open cabinet. Waking up in cold sweat and taking an excruciating moment to remember where she is.

She starts forcing herself not to think about it when she's awake and focus on other memories that feel nearly just as surreal. Waking up in Adora's arms. Adora's hand holding hers as Entrapta works on getting the chip out. Adora formally introducing her to her friends. Adora's face so close to hers as they're lying in bed together. Adora's soft golden hair wrapped around her fingers. Adora's intoxicating scent on her pillow. Adora, Adora, Adora everywhere. Adora knocking on her door right now.

Ugh, she's being terrible again. Shouldn't she be overjoyed? Isn't this exactly what she's always wanted – for Adora to care about her so clearly and openly?

Most times talking to her feels easier than breathing, like nothing bad ever happened between them. They fall into their old rhythm of banter, reminiscence and make jokes and Catra can feel it again, this bond connecting them, one she used to think was long gone. She oddly enjoys learning all about the new Adora. There are things that haven't changed much: she still likes sleeping on hard mattresses, still distracts herself with punching things when she's stressed, and still refuses to wear anything that isn't her signature red jacket. Others are a little less expected. Turns out she is now really into horses and can list off far more details about her magical pony than Catra would ever wish to know. She also discovered that she loves blueberry pie, early morning walks in the forest, beating everyone at board games, and woodcarving (even though, as she feels compelled to mention every time she

shows one of her crudely carved figurines, she's only started recently and isn't very good at it).

She also smiles more often. It's this gentle, truly soft smile spreading on her face, which Catra can't quite recall ever seeing her with back in the Horde. Being on the receiving end of that smile spills a giddy warmth in her chest and she forgets how to do anything but stare at Adora, brain short-circuiting at how breath-taking she is.

But sometimes Adora has this darker, featherlight expression moving across her face, sucking in her lower lip, and visibly hesitates. She usually follows it up with something innocuous and a short awkward laugh, but Catra sees her saying so much more with those looks.

I don't really trust you.

I'm being overly nice, so you won't start acting like such a bitch again.

I'm not sure if I even want you here.

Each of those looks is like a bucket of ice-cold water spilling over Catra, violently pulling her out of a dream. Suddenly there's no more Adora telling her excitedly about what sort of flowers she plans on showing her once they're in Bright Moon gardens, there's just Catra with a pulsating wound on the back of her neck, Catra leaving Adora hanging off the edge of a cliff, sending Entrapta to the Beast Island, opening the portal, stepping into the green pool…

The knocking repeats, a little more forceful this time, and she covers her head with a pillow.

She's so fucking ungrateful. After everything Adora's done for her, if she wants to constantly walk in on Catra to ask if wants tea or invite her to sleepovers with the people she's tried to kill, then she at least owes it to her to try.

Sometimes Adora is gone for an hour and Catra misses her so badly already it feels like she might die. Sometimes Adora comes in to check on her and Catra wants to scream at her to leave.

Her brain is a scrambled mess of raging emotions and it feels terrible subjecting anyone else to them.

"I'm fine, Adora," she yells towards the door before returning to the safety of her pillow. She hopes Adora will take the hint and go away, then immediately chastises herself for the thought.

Her ear twitches when she hears the door open, and there's that. It's that little ball of anger rising up in her chest again, just like all those times with Scorpia, when the world just fizzles out around her for a moment, she sits up, and she hears herself saying the words before she can think:

"Adora, I told you I'm *fine*! Why can't you just leave me alone for even a minute—"

She stops abruptly, when her gaze is met by a wide-eyed pink figure in the doorway, that is decisively not Adora.

"Wow," Glimmer grins at her, thermos in one hand, a bag of snacks in the other. "Aren't you a little ray of sunshine today."

Catra already feels a rush of heat to her cheeks, as her anger instantly evaporates to be replaced by a deep sense of shame.

"Oh, uh…" she stammers. "I… didn't realize it was you."

"Clearly," Glimmer says, walking up to her bed and placing the items on the nightstand. "Oh, wait. Is now a bad time? Are you busy right now?"

She sweeps a look over the bed which has clear signs of Catra having been buried in it recently.

"Har-har," Catra says. "What are you doing here?"

"Visiting," With a dramatic flick of her cape, she sits on the edge of the bed with no hesitation, then grabs one of Catra's pillows to place on her lap. She looks Catra up and down – the food-stained pyjamas, the skin under her eyes a shade of dark purple, the sad unevenly cut hair that obscure her vision no matter how much she pushes it back. Suddenly, Catra feels so awfully small, like she's just shrunk under Glimmer's gaze. She can't believe it feels almost intimidating to sit by the person who got drunk and bawled because she couldn't figure out how to take her boots off just a few days prior.

Come to think of it, they haven't really talked alone since Glimmer's escape, which now feels like a lifetime ago. Although the queen was perfectly pleasant to her when they sat all together for dinner, Catra lowkey assumed she wouldn't really be interested in coming to see her again, now that she's not locked up and has more favourable companion options at her disposal. Well, unless she's just feeling sorry for her.

But Glimmer looks at her with a carefully curious expression rather than a pitiful one.

"How're you feeling?" she asks.

Catra would normally dread the question, but she's spent enough time with Adora to practice the perfect response. "I'm fine," she says automatically.

Glimmer crooks her head incredulously. "Rrrrright."

"No, really, I'm—"

"Oh, cut the crap, Catra. I doubt this even works on Adora," Glimmer waves her hand dismissively.

Catra's first instinct is double down in denial, but for some incomprehensible reason she bites it back. "I'm… Well, alive, I guess," she says on an exhale. "Physically, at least."

"Adora's managed to heal you up?"

"Pretty much," Catra stretches out her arm as if to examine it for any leftover wounds. She vaguely remembers the sound of her bones cracking in Prime's lair right before she passed out. Being able to move at all now feels absolutely unreal. "I was exhausted for the first day or so, but it's been fine since then."

"Mhm," Glimmer hums, eyeing her closely. "So, just so we're clear. You're not wounded or anything?"

"Not anymore, I'm not."

"You're fine?"

"Yes, I'm fine. Why are you being so weird about it?"

"Awesome!" Glimmer stands up, placing the pillow carefully back on the bed and cheerfully claps her hands together. "That means, I get to do *this*."

And, without a warning, she stretches back and smacks Catra over the head, hard. It's unexpected enough to knock off her balance and Catra tumbles off the bed, tangled in sheets, and lands her ass down on the floor.

It takes her an embarrassing second to get back up. "Ow… What the FUCK, Sparkles?!" she yells, rubbing the back of her head with one hand and her butt with the other.

"Well, what the fuck to you too!" Glimmer says, stomping closer, fists on her hips. She really must have been wrapped up in some dark sorcery, because she genuinely looks taller than Catra remembered.

"What was that for?!"

"Ah, let's see," Glimmer flares her nostrils furiously and her fist curl tighter as if they're itching for another punch. "You lied to me. You said you had a plan to get us out of Prime's ship—"

"I didn't lie, it just wasn't—"

"*Don't interrupt m*e – and then you just drag me out of my cell and throw me out into outer space like you're emptying the trash chute?!"

Catra is suddenly glad there is a large piece of furniture between them. She feels her ears drawing back and her tail swinging anxiously.

"You're just full of gratitude, aren't you?" she retorts. "I saved your *life*, in case you haven't noticed!"

"Ooooh, look at me, I'm Catra! I'm just so *noble* and *heroic*, I'm gonna save the Queen of Bright Moon's life, even though nobody fucking asked me to!" Glimmer slams her hands on the bed.

"What is your problem?!" Catra hears her own voice treacherously trembling. "I tried to do something good! I told Adora to stay away, I don't know what else could you possibly want from me!" She swallows thickly. "You should have… left me on Prime's ship if you hate me so much!"

Glimmer runs a hand across her face and releases a long, exasperated groan. "My *problem*," she jabs a finger in Catra's direction. "Is that you wanted to sacrifice yourself. And I'm not exactly a-okay with *my friend* dying for my sake, you triangle-eared moron!"

They stand still, leaning on the opposite sides of the bedframe, as silence hangs in the air between them.

"Oh," after what feels like a lifetime, Catra manages in a high-pitched voice, "Fuck off."

She slumps back down on the floor and hides her face behind her knees.

She pushes her back against the bed, feels her shoulders shaking and can't will them to stop. The feeble defenses she's managed to build over the past week collapse just like that stupid little box of a storage room in the Fright Zone, and she can't even think

anymore, just feel. Anger, hurt, fear, confusion, love – everything mixed up together, a revolting soup of emotion swirling in her stomach. She wants to throw up all over the place.

A hand grabbing her arm startles her. She didn't even notice Glimmer sinking down by her side. She reaches over Catra's back and pulls her closer. They sit like this wordlessly for what feels like eternity, Glimmer smoothing a hand over her shoulder with solemn determination.

Finally, Catra manages to force the words out in between shaky breaths: "Your taste in friends has gone to absolute shit, Sparkles."

Glimmer snorts with laughter, then leans back to look at her face. "Yeah, what can you do. One minute you get locked up with some stinky Horde Scum, the next you braid each other's hair and save each other's lives."

Catra chuckles, the choking ball of tightness in her chest slowly shrinking.

"It's just… a lot," she sighs, throwing her head back and dropping her arms to the floor. "And I wasn't even supposed to be here, you know? I didn't… plan for this."

Glimmer just nods her head slowly, understandingly. She attempts to tuck a strand of hair behind Catra's ear, but it immediately falls back down.

"It's hard to talk about this and I just… I don't know." Catra trails off lamely. "I don't want to bore you with all of this."

Glimmer's hand abruptly stops rubbing small circles on Catra's back.

"Okay, are you even being serious right now." Glimmer asks flatly. "After everything you've already told me back in my cell, *now* you wanna be shy?"

She reaches to squish Catra's face in one hand, forcing her to look into her purple, determined eyes.

"Uh," Catra manages.

"Okay, fine," Glimmer lets go of her face and for a second, Catra feels a little sting of disappointment thinking she's given up. "I'm going to drag this out of you the old way."

Catra's ears perk up. "The old way?"

Glimmer rises to her knees and then pulls a curled fist from her back pocket. There is a slightly crumpled piece of paper in it, that looks awfully familiar.

"It's my drawing of you," Catra recognizes, before theatrically pouting. "I thought you were supposed treasure it, not shove it down your back pocket."

"I'm keeping it close to the things that really matter," Glimmer gives her a smug smile while straightening the paper. "We're somewhat short on alcohol here and I don't feel like pushups are appropriate for the gravity of this discussion. But make no mistake, we're keeping score." She takes out a pencil and quickly sketches a crude table on the clear side of the paper, marking the headers with BRAT CAT and BIG G. Something inside Catra's head finally clicks.

"You want to make this into a game?"

"Clearly, if nothing else works on you," Glimmer grumbles, carefully embellishing the letters. "I hope you appreciate just how patient I am with you."

"You literally smacked me over the head a few minutes ago."

"Consider how long I've been holding it back, though," she clears her throat. "Right. You wanna go first, or should I?"

“Wait,” Catra says through another failed attempt to push her hair back. “What’s the endgame with this one?”

Glimmer bites the tip of the pencil, considering. “Let’s see, I keep the score, and whoever wins is awesome, and whoever loses has to publicly admit that we’re friends.”

Catra shudders. “You’re quite the gambler, you know that?”

“You probably should have realized that back when I used to distract you with Adora to gain tactical advantage over the Horde,” Glimmer says calmly, reaching for the thermos and the bag, which turns out to contain a multitude of icing-covered cupcakes.

“Thanks,” Catra reaches for a cupcake, trying to hide what she suspects is a look of admiration. “You can go first, Big G.”

“How gracious of you,” Glimmer wastes no time helping herself to another cupcake. “Here’s my assumption, then: you were so honest with me back on Prime’s ship, because you thought at least one of us would die.”

Catra takes a small bite and lets the sweetness of the strawberry-flavoured filling melt on her tongue before speaking. “Yeah, that’s about right.”

Glimmer marks down a triumphant stick under the BIG G column. “So you *did* lie to me, didn’t you? You told me you were so sure Bow and Adora would come to my rescue and everything would be fine.”

“I meant that. I just mostly thought *I* was gonna die,” Catra shrugs. “I couldn’t really see a way out of all this for me. And frankly, I didn’t even care that much.”

“Well, now you’re just being blasé on purpose.”

“Am not!” Catra bites down on her cupcake with determination. “Iff jufft… I ffought I waff gonna die right before Prime snatched us up. Maybe… in some way I even wanted to.”

She recalls lying on the Fright Zone's floor, the place burning up around her, Glimmer standing over her with a staff in her hand and hatred in her eyes. Despair drowning her so completely it felt like she didn't exist already.

Glimmer sniffs shortly. "Yeah, I figured. You literally asking me to off you sort of gave me that idea."

Catra snorts into her cupcake, feeling an embarrassing wave of gratitude for the overly serious mood getting shattered. "Nothing gets past you, does it?"

"Certainly not a Horde Scum who's lost her will to live. Though I still can't find the connection between this, and you beginning to ritually turn up at my cell for sleepovers."

Catra looks down at her feet, rested on the ship's perfectly shiny purple floor.

"I think I just… didn't care?" she says, eyes anywhere but on Glimmer. She takes a deep breath and says the next string of words in a rush, before she can change her mind: "I thought I was done for and, for a minute, it felt a whole lot like relief. Then I realized quickly enough that Prime isn't likely to keep me around for decoration once my usefulness runs out, and I couldn't do much to help it, so… I figured I might as well do whatever the hell I felt like, without worrying what anyone thinks of me, for once."

Her gaze finally darts to Glimmer, who's watching her like she's a particularly challenging quiz problem.

"And the first thing you decided to do was… go and hang out with me?"

"I was… curious about you, I guess? Part of me always wondered if you're really as lame as you seemed, or if there was something about this pink glitter-pooping princess worth leaving me over."

"Okay, first off – you know nothing about my poops, Catra," says Glimmer with emphasis. "And second – did you find out

anything?”

“Just that you’re an almost complete opposite of the person I’ve always imagined you to be,” Catra waves her half-eaten cupcake around. “I mean, I’d leave me for you. But then again, I thought I hated myself more than Adora hated me.”

“Dumbass,” Glimmer concludes, pushing a thermos into her hands. “Have some tea and shut the hell up.”

“You asked for an elaboration!”

“And now I’m asking you to shut your cute face.”

Catra chuckles, then takes a swig off tea.

“Oh, but, first!” Glimmer points her finger at Catra’s face. “There’s one more thing you never really got to explain – what the hell happened that made you ghost me for a few days?”

The question takes Catra by surprise, even though she should have known it was coming. Sparkles isn’t quite the type to let things go too easily.

“Had a bit of a wake-up call,” she shrugs. “Prime took me to his throne room and basically threatened me, with far too much talking and demonstration for my liking.”

She shudders at the memory. “I… got scared. Which clearly meant that I still cared, and that destroyed my comfortable illusion. It’s like I got snapped back into reality and it sucked, because it meant I needed to admit to myself that I cared, and I had to something about it.”

“I thought you couldn’t really do anything?”

“Well, not for my own sake, I couldn’t. But…” she inhales deeply “…there were others… I cared about… and needed to figure out how to help them.”

Beside her, Glimmer shifts in her seat.

"Horde Scum," she says. "You nightmare. You stinky little Brat Cat. Is this… Is this your way of telling me that you *cared* about me?"

"Absolutely fucking not," Catra monotones. "Ugh, I just… I needed a few days to mull it all over and figure out a way to get you off that ship, okay? And I tried to come up with a plan that would involve the both of us making a run for it, really."

"…buuuut could only find one that involved you sacrificing yourself for my sake?"

Catra nods slowly, taking another drag from the thermos. Glimmer stares, her face indecipherable.

"I feel like hugging you right now," she says eventually.

"Please don't."

Catra offers a forced smile. Maybe normally she wouldn't object to the idea as much, but she's made up her mind now – she genuinely cares about this person. And that means, for better or worse, she has another thing to address.

"Hey. My turn, right?" she asks, passing the thermos back and squinting at Glimmer in focus. She takes a deep breath, bracing herself to say something she'd been wanting to for a while now. "You've kinda grown to like me back on Prime's ship, in a strange-yet-desperate way and… for that sake, you avoided talking about your mother and the part I played in her death."

A loaded silence falls between them.

Back on Prime's ship, there was an unspoken agreement born out of necessity that their fragile relationship hinged on the two of them avoiding the subject at all costs. But now that they're back out in the real world, there's hardly any reason to ignore it anymore. *Catra* doesn't want to ignore it anymore.

It’s probably over now, this weird friendship they had. But it could never be real with the shadow of Queen Angella looming over them.

And that would probably be even sadder than Glimmer never speaking to her again. Catra clenches her jaw, breaths coming shallow. She’s used to others ending whatever relationships they had with her, but never before while she was actively trying to fix them.

Eventually, Glimmer shifts in her seat, lifts the pencil and places a vertical line under BRAT CAT.

“I had to consider if you deserve it for such an obvious one,” she says with a grin.

Catra isn’t sure if she should interpret this as an encouragement, but and since she got this far, there is no backing out of it now. She probably wouldn’t even want to. “I’m sorry, Glimmer,” she says quietly. “You know all about why I did it, but it’s not like that is any excuse. If you don’t want to be around me anymore, I’ll understand.”

Glimmer groans loudly, throwing her head back. “This may shock you, but I already knew you opened the portal before just now. And that didn’t stop me from wanting to be friends with you.” Catra must be staring, because she adds: “Look, it’s not like I don’t think you’ve done anything wrong. It’s just that, I get it. It’d be pretty hypocritical of me to hold it against you after I, too, have done an idiotic disastrous thing because I was really pissed.”

She pats the top of Catra’s head very officially. “I’m glad you’ve apologized, though.”

She takes a pull of tea, then reaches down for another cupcake with a smile, letting her words settle between them like the icing on top of it.

“Do you… uh…” Catra stammers. “…wanna talk more about it?”

"Well, now that that's out of the way, I can tell you all about my mum one of these days," she says, letting some of the cupcake's filling drip on her knee, then disgustingly licking it off. "Unless you mean apologizing. We could do more of that."

"Okay," Catra clears her throat. "I'm… also sorry for kidnapping you."

"I'm sorry for kidnapping you back."

"I'm sorry for attacking your kingdom."

"Sorry I tried to kill you a bunch of times."

"Sorry I bit you."

"Sorry I called you a sour little bitchbaby like a hundred times."

"I don't remember you ever doing that?"

"Yeah, not to your face, I didn't."

Catra laughs, sinking down farther on the floor. She sees Glimmer above her, pink-faced and definitely pleased with herself.

"Alright, time for round three," she pokes at Catra's forehead with the pad of her thumb. "You said the reason you could spill all the juiciest details of your life since day two of us being prison buddies was because you didn't care, as much of a logical stretch that is. Which can only mean that you're struggling to be honest with Adora, because you care like, *a lot.*"

Catra bites down on her cheek. "What makes you think I'm not being honest with Adora?"

"She says so. She's really concerned about that, in fact," Glimmer says, hovering over her. Faintly, Catra remembers still having her mask on the last time they were in this exact position.

"I'm not spending my time here lying to her."

“But she can feel that you’re holding back,” carefully, Glimmer makes another feeble attempt to push Catra’s hair back. “You’re not telling her everything that’s in this gross little head of yours the way you’re telling me.”

Catra takes a moment to collect herself off the floor and rubs the heel of her hand against her forehead. “I… didn’t realize she’s even noticed.”

“I know Adora can be a little more on the dense side, emotionally, but she’s got a lot more compassionate since you two were in the Horde. She’s really trying, at least.”

“I know, I know, it’s just,” Catra coughs. “I can’t really bring myself to it. The way she looks at me sometimes…”

“The way she looks at you?” Glimmer frowns at her.

“Like she’s worried I might backstab her again any second. And I can’t really blame her, can I?” Catra offers a very bitter laugh.

Her stomach sinks at a mere memory of Adora’s unsure smiles, tiny muscles tensing in her jaw, her eyes tracking over Catra as if she’s trying to discreetly search her for any hidden weapons. In a way, it feels more heartbreaking than a genuine punch to the face.

“Did she… say anything about that?” Glimmer leans forward.

“Well… not exactly, but…”

“Has it occurred to you that maybe she’s just *worried about you*?” Glimmer attempts, cocking her head to the side.

“Uh,” Catra says, frowning in focus. “Well, um. I mean…”

“Yikes. I thought you were supposed to be the smart one.”

“Shut your face! It’s not like that, I don’t think—”

“Didn’t her checking in on you every five minutes clue you in at all?”

“I thought she was checking if I’m up to something…”

“Ugh, are all the former Horde soldier lesbians this dense, or is just you and Adora?” Glimmer pinches the bridge of her nose impatiently. “She literally can’t shut up about you whenever she’s out of your room. *Catra looked sad again, what do you think I can do to cheer her up? Do we have a tea that can stop you from having nightmares? Oh, I think I’m starting to annoy Catra constantly hovering over her, but I can’t stand leaving her, what if she feels bad again and I’m not there?”*

Catra’s eyes dart to the side and she folds her arms over her chest defensively. “I…” A sudden ding of realization. “Wait. She’s *a lesbian*?”

Glimmer inhales deeply and releases a sound from her throat that resembles a wild boar in agony. “What a spectacular way to answer my question, truly!” She throws a pillow at her, and Catra can’t help but to fall back down in laughter again. Such a dumb trick from Sparkles that really shouldn’t work on her by now, but it does. “Yes, thanks, we get it! You’re two emotionally constipated idiots thirsting for each other, but could you please stop making my life so difficult over it and *just talk*?”

“It’s not so easy, Sparkles-“ Catra’s cut off mid-sentence, as Glimmer makes a huge farting noise and starts poking at her sides, and she scream-laughs on the floor.

“I don’t *care*! Make out with her then! Eat each other out! I am literally so done with you two!”

Catra finally manages to smack unsuspecting Glimmer’s half-open mouth with her tail and crawl away in a moment of distraction, face still heated from laughter.

“Great, now I’ve got cat hair in my mouth, thanks!” Glimmer attempts to wipe her tongue on the back of her hand.

“Serves you right for getting all this damn glitter all over me.”

“I’m going to kill you,” she threatens, tumbling down while trying to reach out and claw at Catra’s leg.

Among these frantic movements, they end up effectively rolling over each other, limbs tangled together on the floor, in a way that would leave a whole lot to explain if Adora suddenly decided to check on them right now. As they slowly let their giggles die out, it somehow manages to transform into a firm, horizonal hug.

It briefly crosses Catra’s mind that she’s never hugged anyone except Adora this way and in some idiotic way, it almost feels like cheating.

“Really, though,” Glimmer says, having finally caught some breath. “You *do* know the deadly combo of Adora having the emotional intelligence of a brick wall, and your inability to tell her about your feelings straight on, is what caused this entire three-year old dumpster fire that we’re all in? Cause Adora seems to have realized that. And she’s really trying to fix it the best she can, so… you might wanna meet her half-way.”

Catra reaches up to pat the glittery pink hair, as a way of agreement.

They fight for a bit over the best seat on Catra’s bed, before deciding that they could actually use more snacks and remembering there is nothing holding them confined to a single room anymore. Glimmer excitedly grabs her hand and leads her out into a spacious hallway, low-lit with brilliant shades of blue and purple. The gentle darkness of the place is something Catra finds oddly comforting now.

“Where’s everyone else?” She asks. Having spent the majority of her time on Mara’s ship hiding in her room like a recluse, she didn’t familiarize herself with the place well-enough. She can do little but awkwardly follow in Glimmer’s footsteps.

“Hanging out in the controls room,” Glimmer says, not stopping. She quickly adds: “We can join them later, but remember we still have a game to finish.”

They arrive in a spacious kitchen-slash-pantry, where Glimmer immediately starts rummaging through the cupboards in search of the goods. Catra watches her with a small smile, as she leans forward, folding her arms on the counter.

“Hey, you might want to note down another point for me,” she says to Glimmer’s back.

“Yeah, what for?” asks Glimmer through a clumsy attempt at climbing the shelf to reach a box of biscuits on top. It couldn’t be clearer that she’s not used to life without teleporting. Catra graciously jumps up to grabs the box, then swiftly hops to sit on the countertop.

“Speaking of making out,” she says, handing the biscuits to Glimmer, swinging tail betraying her amusement. “You and Bow clearly got down to business already, huh?”

It’s quite a sight, the queen of Bright Moon clinging to the food shelf for dear life, face flashing bright red. She grabs the box and jumps down with as much dignity as she can muster.

“Glad at least *someone* noticed,” she smiles mischievously. “Thought we might just hold off the announcement right up until our wedding day.”

“Oooh, things getting that serious already?”

“Well, I mean,” she coughs. “We haven’t really… defined anything. We had a bit of a rough start, but then… I don’t know, things just changed.”

She pivots on the spot and dives into another cabinet to hide the dumb dreamy smile spreading across her blushing face. A part of Catra wants to groan at that, but another can’t help feeling genuinely happy for her pink little gremlin.

"You mean to tell me every time Adora's busy crying over me and Entrapta's busy romancing the ship, the two of you snuggle up together to suck faces, but you're not sure if you're in a relationship?" she asks with poorly concealed glee.

Glimmer simply throws a candy bar at her head in response.

Catra ducks with ease, flashing her fangs in a grin spreading even wider. "Makes sense, Arrow Bow seems like the kind of person who'd swap spit with his best friend but want to keep things casual."

"How many gross euphemisms for kissing do you know, Horde Scum?" Glimmer rubs a hand across her face, but neither her blush nor her smile fades away. "Just you wait until I start talking details about his abs again."

"Ugh. Where's the space alcohol when you need it?"

"Try checking up your butt," Glimmer walks up to place a few more snack-filled boxes by her side. "There's a cellar-like room in here, but it looks like it's been completely looted fairly recently."

"Oh," Catra's stomach sinks a little and she blinks a few times. "Come to think of it, this may actually be my fault."

"How so?"

"I… threw a party in here once, remember? They must have used it all up back then." She rubs the back of her head, letting the strands of hair fall over her eyes again. "When I… you know…"

"…stole Adora's sword and then *swapped spit* with Scorpia?" Glimmer offers, smirking.

Well, yes, that was it, more or less. She's been on this ship before, after all, but the context was so different, it may have as well happened in another life. It almost feels like the ghost of old Catra could walk in here any second now, nonchalantly carrying She-ra's

sword on her back. The new Catra isn't sure if she'd like to kick her ass or console her. Probably a bit of both.

Catra hides her face in her elbow. "Of all my life's regrets, befriending you is the biggest one yet."

"Just wait until you have to do a presentation on all the reasons you like me to the entire Princess Alliance," says Glimmer serenely.

"Why would I have to do that?"

"Cause you're about to lose our game," Glimmer swipes the hair away from Catra's forehead. "Here's my next assumption. You're in desperate need for a haircut."

She shifts and reveals something she must have grabbed from one of the drawers while Catra was distracted – a small pair of scissors.

Catra sucks down on her teeth. "You think I haven't had enough haircuts lately?" she arches an eyebrow.

"I think whoever did your last haircut clearly meant for it to be slicked back at all times. And I'm sorry, but that's just not your style."

"Adora says it looks cute," Catra mumbles helplessly, pulling on a strand of her hair.

"Adora would see you walking in with bird's nest on your head and tell you it looks cute. Meanwhile, I'm the voice of stylish reason here, and I say you need bangs," She eyes the floppy hair over Catra's eyes like a hungry predator. "Just let me fix it up a bit. Please?"

"Top reasons to like you, huh?" Catra sighs in defeat. "Number one, your unhealthy obsession with giving me a makeover."

She sits herself on one of the barstools, legs crossed, and lets Glimmer work around her head, strands of hair falling to the floor

with every snap of scissors. It's quite different from the rough cut one of Prime's clones gave her the second she got out of the pool. She remembers the whole thing as if through a thick green fog and places both hands on her knee to stop it from nervously jerking.

"Here," Glimmer finally hands her a small mirror she produces from the drawer. The little shit must have had this whole thing planned in advance.

It's shorter than Catra ever remembers it to be, and sticks out in the funniest directions, but somehow it looks… her. Most importantly, her bangs are finally back, and as small of a gesture as it may be, it feels like a big fuck you to Shadow Weaver. Even better.

"I don't… hate it," she says, twirling the longer strand by her ear.

"Well, good. I wanted you to look presentable," Glimmer says proudly, reaching for the drawer again. "For when we introduce you to everyone."

"I somehow don't think they'll welcome me with open arms, no matter how good my haircut is," Catra scoffs, still moving the mirror around, trying to get a proper look at her haircut from every angle.

"No point in stressing yourself in advance," Glimmer says in a sing-song voice. "They may not all like you, but they'll need to accept - my new royal advisor."

With an emphatic smack, she slaps a thick neat-looking pink folder on the counter. It's filled with a stack of papers, which would look a whole lot like those Catra used to spend so many nights over as the Horde Commander, were they not covered in a swirly font and scented.

Catra nearly drops the mirror at the realization.

“Sparkles, this isn’t the best of your ideas,” she says, pressing lips together.

“Too bad, because I’ve already made my decision,” Glimmer says, leaning on the counter. “Look, it’s clear that I still have a lot to learn on how to do all the queen things and insisting on making every call myself was a little bit of a fucking disaster. I need someone who has the experience, has the brains, and whom I can trust.”

“And you don’t you need someone your royal subjects don’t despise?” she places the mirror back on the counter and gets up to pace around the kitchen, feeling her ears drawing back already.

“If we’re going to defeat Prime,” Glimmer says, ignoring her, “then I need all the Horde’s efficiency and ingenuity that used to piss me off so much, for my side. I need *you*, Catra.”

Abruptly, she steps right in Catra’s tracks and violently pushes the folder into her arms.

Catra opens it indulgently and slowly flicks through the pages. It’s all bullet lists, elaborate tables and charts on every Etherian land and connections between them. Trade routes. Diplomatic intel. Defense strategies.

Suddenly her pulse speeds up. On one hand, it’s honestly terrifying how quickly Glimmer just hands all of Etheria’s most sensitive information to someone who’s been on her side for about five minutes. On the other… She remembers how good she got at this stuff, especially once Shadow Weaver left the Horde. Diving into planning and arranging was a welcome distraction from all the other mess happening in her life, so she used to concentrate on it as often as she could. Right of the bat, her hand starts itching for a pen, so she could mark down some improvements in the Bright Moon papers.

But no. This is just too stupid.

“You know the princesses will never accept me…” she mutters.

“They accepted Adora, Scorpia, Entrapta… Hell, even Shadow Weaver, to an extent,” Glimmer rolls her eyes. “If I could give you a chance, so can they. And if not, well, I might just need to lock you up with each of them for a few weeks.”

Catra hugs the folder to her chest. “Few weeks each? That’s going to take ages.”

“We’ll do a speedrun. With double the booze and cards.”

She has the most viciously determined look on her face and Catra can’t help but smile at that. She feels like her heart is stuck somewhere up in her throat again, but for entirely different reasons than usual.

Okay, this seems like an abysmal idea in theory. But so was deflecting from Horde Prime, wasn’t it?

“I… guess you’d need someone with planning skills,” Catra releases a short, wet laugh. “I mean, before Adora dragged me in here, this ship contained a total number of maybe five brain cells, with Entrapta having a solid hold on at least three of them.”

“Deal?” Glimmer triumphantly extends her hand.

“Deal,” Catra mimics the gesture, receiving one of the firmest handshakes in her career in return.

“Right!” Glimmer claps her hands enthusiastically, beaming at her like a proud parent. “Let’s take all of this and join the rest of these dorks.”

“Thought you wanted to finish the game?”

“It’s over, I won. I assumed you wanted the job. You can expire in a sugar haze with everyone else now, come on.” She pulls on Catra’s arms, nearly knocking a chair over in a rush to leave.

Then she releases a startled yelp, as they almost bump into Bow and Adora in the kitchen’s doorway.

“There you two are,” Bow says, folding his arms. “We’ve been looking all over the ship for you. Thought you might have jumped off at some point.”

Adora wastes no time sliding by Catra’s side and grabbing her arm. “You’re okay?” She asks her immediately.

“Yeah, I’m fine,” Catra smiles at her, this time actually meaning it. There are still some things they need to talk over, but for the first time, she feels like they actually can. She briefly squeezes Adora’s arm in return.

Adora beams at her with *that* smile, which lifts Catra’s heart all the way up and sends a little pleasant shiver down her spine. If Bow and Glimmer weren’t here, she could have kissed her on the spot.

“What do you have there?” Bow points at the folder with his chin.

“It’s Glimmer’s diary,” Catra deadpans. “She writes that she’s super in love with me, it’s sooo embarrassing.”

Glimmer kicks at her shin and they all burst out laughing, though Catra can’t help but notice Adora pulling her a little bit closer.

“Wanna join us for charades?” Bow asks. “Entrapta and Wrong Hordak are waiting for us already.”

“Ooooh, Catra and I are about to *destroy* you!” Adora says, cracking her knuckles, face blushed with excitement. “You might not know this, but when we were little, we developed this whole secret language…”

Catra huffs a laugh and exchanges a quick meaningful look with Glimmer over Adora’s shoulder.

Over the haze of animated voices and laughter, one arm over Glimmer’s folder, the other still in Adora’s grip, Catra releases a long-held breath. Maybe she doesn’t need her storage room anymore. It would get crowded with all of them anyway.

Chapter End Notes

A big thank you to my lovely Maria, my biggest motivation and the best Glimmer inspiration I could ask for.

Another big thank you to Ola and Andi, my writing guinea pigs.

And to everyone who's stuck with reading all the way through - thank you so much! Every kudo and comment means the world to me and really fires me up to create more content.

Hope you enjoyed this little fic and until next time!

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